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Narendra Modi

POLICY PARALYSIS TO DYNAMISM: AT SRCC, MODI LAYS OUT GROWTH ARC

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said India had moved from policy paralysis to policy dynamism in 13 years, returning to Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) to claim vindication for the case he had made in 2013 from the same stage before he came to power. Modi last addressed SRCC in February 2013, when his party was in Opposition and he was a year away from national office. Speaking at the college's centenary celebrations, Modi said his 2013 address had set off a "wave", and attacked those who had pushed India into the "Fragile Five" and were now "unable to digest its 7.8% growth". Achieving a 7.8% quarterly growth amidst the West Asia war and global trade hurdles demonstrates India's intrinsic capability," he said. **→P3**

Census to begin early in 4 poll-bound states: Centre sets Dec 1 date

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NEW DELHI: The Centre has moved the population count in Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Goa and parts of Uttarakhand to December, two months ahead of the rest of the country, clearing the census out of the quarter in which all four states are expected to go to the polls, according to a gazette notification issued on Saturday. The advance means the first caste enumeration in independent India will likely be held weeks prior to people in these four states casting their vote. Enumerators will begin door-to-door work in the four states on December 1 and finish on January 4, with a revision round — a short follow-up to update households that changed after the first visit — running to January 9. Self-enumeration, under which residents enter their household details online before an enumerator calls, opens on November 16. **→P3**

New schedule for four states

Census 2027
States covered: Self-enumeration: Nov 16-30, 2026
Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, parts of Uttarakhand
Field enumeration: Dec 1, 2026 - Jan 4, 2027
Revision round: Jan 5-9, 2027
Reference date: 00:00 hours, Jan 5, 2027

Reasoning for early dates: Officials aware of the matter said the dates were advanced in poll-bound states to ensure manpower is available for elections as well as the Census. The Opposition, however, said the move indicated "infectious political calculations".
Exercise in Manipur deferred: The Registrar General of India deferred the Census in Manipur "till further declaration", formalising an August 31 decision amid continuing violence and demands to update the NRC before the population count.

The rest of the country will be counted from February. A senior official aware of the matter, who asked not to be named, said "the dates for poll-bound states have been advanced to have manpower available for elections as well as Census, because a large number of staff used in both the exercises are teachers or state government staff". Teachers and state government employees staff both the census and polling booths. In the last elections in these four states, polling began on February 1. **→P3**

CBI books Chandra on complaint by LICHL

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NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed an FIR against Essel Group chairperson and Zee founder Subhash Chandra for allegedly misleading LIC Housing Finance Limited (LICHL), about his net worth when he stood guarantee for two loans that went into default, leaving the public sector lender with a ₹1,322 crore loss.



A look-out circular was issued against Subhash Chandra to prevent him leaving India.

On CBI's request, immigration authorities issued a look-out circular against Chandra at all airports, ports and land entry/exit points to ensure he doesn't leave the country. The Enforcement Directorate is also examining the matter but it is yet to bring a formal probe, said an official aware of the matter. HT called Chandra and left

with three companies, two individuals and other "unknown" people. The allegations pertain to loans LICHL extended to two companies — Vasant Sagar Properties Pvt Ltd and Digital Subscriber Management and Consultancy Services Pvt Ltd — for business expansion and rental securitisation, with Chandra providing personal guarantees for the borrowings. According to LICHL's CBI complaint, which is part of the FIR, Vasant Sagar Properties Pvt Ltd was given a loan facility of ₹500 crore, with Pan India Infra Projects Pvt Ltd as co-borrower, as a home equity loan for business expansion. Similarly, a ₹480 crore loan was given to Digital Subscriber Management and Consultancy Services Pvt Ltd, with Spirit

him text messages, but did not receive a response. An email query to Zee Group's corporate communications did not receive a response either. In a first information report (FIR) filed on August 31, the central agency named Chandra as accused number 1 under sections pertaining to criminal conspiracy, cheating and criminal breach of contract, along

HOPE AMID RUINS: ANOTHER WORKER, WOMAN RESCUED IN FLOOD-HIT NEPAL

KATHMANDU: Personnel in Nepal pulled out a Chinese man and a woman in separate operations on Saturday, 10 days after devastating floods hit the country, as teams continued searching for thousands of missing people. The man was rescued from a hydropower tunnel, bringing the total to three workers pulled alive from the Trishuli hydropower project. In flood-hit Nuwakot town, a woman was rescued from a damaged house. **→P3**

MOSQUE RAZED AT COLLECTORATE IN SAHARANPUR AFTER COURT'S DIRECTIVE

MERUT: The Saharanpur district administration on Saturday demolished a mosque inside the collectorate complex, days after a local court upheld an earlier order declaring the structure illegal, officials said. Authorities sealed all five gates of the collectorate and deployed a heavy security contingent, including the Rapid Action Force (RAF), to maintain law and order during the demolition, officials added. **→P7**

ISRO STAFF BODIES SEEK CLARITY ON SPACE SECTOR PRIVATISATION

MUMBAI: Six years after the government opened the space sector to private companies, thousands of Isro employees represented by nine associations have sought an official clarification on the proposed transfer of the space agency's manufacturing and operational functions to private entities. **→P5**

US strikes 3 Iranian oil tankers, Tehran threatens 'wider attacks'

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DUBAI: US forces struck three Iranian oil tankers on Saturday, U.S. Central Command said, including one off the coast of Kharg Island, near Iran's key oil export hub. The strikes were carried out after Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps launched ballistic missiles at two US Navy ships, Central Command said. "Let the message to the IRGC be clear: If you shoot at two of our ships, we will impose an even higher economic cost — taking out three of yours," said Admiral Brad Cooper, head of US Central Command.

THE STRIKES WERE CARRIED OUT AFTER IRAN'S IRGC LAUNCHED BALLISTIC MISSILES AT TWO US NAVY SHIPS, CENTRAL COMMAND SAID

Tasnim, the semi-official Iranian news agency, reported earlier that four US missiles hit a tanker in the area of Kharg's anchorage. Tasnim quoted local sources as saying there were no casualties and the tanker's crew was being evacuated. A spokesman with Iran's

joint military command later warned that strikes against U.S. military ships would be more severe if the U.S. continues to interfere with Iranian shipping, the state broadcaster reported. No US personnel were harmed, Central Command said. There was no immediate official announcement by Iranian authorities. The exchange of attacks follows an escalation in the past week that threatens to deepen a conflict that has dragged on since the US launched strikes on Iran in February, disrupting global energy supplies and drawing opposition from a majority of Americans before congressional elections in November. **→P13**

Nearly 1.1mn Delhi voters' names deleted from Jan '25 to June '26, before SIR began

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NEW DELHI: The first phase of the special intensive revision (SIR) in Delhi deleted nearly 4.8 million names from the Capital's electoral roll, or roughly a third of the 14.5 million electorate as of June 20. But even before the controversial process began on June 30, Election Commission data shows that nearly 1.1 million names were dropped between

PEOPLE SAID THEY WERE UNAWARE THEIR NAMES WERE DELETED, LEAVING THEM WITHOUT S.I.R. FORMS OR A CHANCE TO ENROL

January 2025 — when it was frozen before the February 2025 assembly elections — and June 2026, when it was frozen before

SIR. This represents around 7.07% of the city's electorate in 2025 and 11.32% now. HT spoke to at least 15 people across the Capital who were not aware that their names were dropped during this 16-month period. As a result, their partially filled forms for SIR were never generated, never reached their booth-level officers, and they never got a chance to enroll themselves. "When SIR started, everybody in my family received an

SIR form except me. We went to the BLO multiple times, but he said my name is not there and I should register afresh later using Form 6," said domestic worker Puja Desi, who voted in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, and lives in Mubarakpur Dabas in northwest Delhi. To be sure, additions and deletions to the electoral roll are a continuous process. If rolls are not frozen, additions can be

Cong replaces Baghel as Punjab in-charge amid internal discord

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NEW DELHI: The Congress on Saturday replaced former Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel with former Rajasthan deputy chief minister Sachin Pilot as the party's general secretary in-charge of Punjab amid signs of discord in the state unit. Punjab in-charge in 2025, Baghel's removal comes against the backdrop of his purportedly strained equation with former CM Charanjit Singh Channi, who has sought the replacement of party's Punjab unit chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, Baghel, however, has favoured no leadership change. Channi said, "A warm welcome to Shri Sachin Pilot. Ji. Heartfelt



Bhupesh Baghel

thanks to the Congress Party High Command for this important decision." Baghel, who was appointed in-charge of Assam, where polls were recently held, to lead a state in 150 T20s, led India to make Pakistan out for 55 in 181 overs, their lowest-ever total in the format. She finished the match with a six down the ground, with more than 10 overs to go. **→P6**

JANTAR MANTAR ASSAULT: RIGHT-WING CREATOR REMANDED IN POLICE CUSTODY

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Saturday sent right-wing content creator Swatantra Bharachwa to a day's police custody after he allegedly severely injured a 38-year-old man — who was accompanied by his 14-year-old daughter — during the Jantar Mantar protests, police said. A senior police officer on Saturday confirmed they have added sections of criminal intimidation to the FIR. Meerut District Judge Anand Chaudhary said a complaint with the New Delhi Cyber Cell against the minor and her father for allegedly hurting Hindu sentiments. **HTC**

More showers perpetuate Delhi's pain



Vehicles drive through a waterlogged stretch in Anand Parbat, Delhi, on Saturday. The city's base weather station, Safdarjung, received 29.8mm of rainfall, another wet spell that brought traffic to a standstill and delayed over 100 flights. (SHANT CHAUHAN/HT PHOTO)

8 ENGINEERING STUDENTS KILLED AS CAR RAMS INTO LORRY IN KERALAM

THRISSUR: Eight students from an engineering college in Tamil Nadu were killed after their car rammed into a lorry parked "illegally" on NH-66 in Thrissur district of central Kerala, police said on Saturday. According to officers, the deceased were students of an engineering college in Dindigul and were travelling from Guruvayur towards Kodungalur along NH-66 when the accident took place. Police have registered a case against the lorry's driver, who police said was on the run. **→P5**

10 convicted in 2013 Maoist attack that killed 29

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RAIPUR: A special NIA court in the Bastar district of Chhattisgarh on Saturday convicted all 10 accused over the 2013 Jharia Valley Maoist attack, which killed 29 people and nearly wiped out the Congress leadership in the state. The court will announce the quantum of punishment for September 16. On May 25, 2013, Maoists ambushed a Congress convey returning from a public meeting ahead of the state assembly elections. The insurgents triggered an IED blast on the national highway in Jharia Valley in the Sukma district and then started firing at the vehicles indiscriminately. Then state Congress chief Nand Kumar Patel and his son Dinesh, former Leader of Opposition in the assembly Mahendra Karma, former Union minister Vidya Charan Shukla, and senior Congress leader Uday Mudliyar were among the 29 politicians, civilians and security personnel killed. Defence lawyer Arvind Chaudhary said they will challenge the verdict in the high court. **→P4**

Strike that decimated state Cong leadership
HOW THE ATTACK UNFOLDED
On May 25, 2013, Maoists ambushed a Congress convey returning from a public meeting ahead of state polls. The insurgents triggered an IED blast on the national highway. They then started firing indiscriminately. Then state Congress chief Nand Kumar Patel and his son Dinesh, former LoP in the assembly Mahendra Karma, ex-Union minister Vidya Charan Shukla, and senior Cong leader Uday Mudliyar were among the dead.



INDIA ROUT PAK IN WOMEN'S ASIA CUP GROUP CLASH

DUBAI: India eased past Pakistan by seven wickets in the Women's Asia Cup T20 on Saturday, with spinners Shree Chaurani and Prema Rawat taking six wickets between them. Harmanpreet Kaur, who became the first international captain — make or break — to lead a team in 150 T20s, led India to bowl Pakistan out for 55 in 181 overs, their lowest-ever total in the format. She finished the match with a six down the ground, with more than 10 overs to go. **→P6**



Are we going to be the death of...

...the IBK, the dinky hatchback? Once the stuff of middle-class dreams, these things are fading from view. This is a trend we worked towards and hoped for. We have gained, and still stand to gain. But what do we stand to lose? An essay by Anshu Parmar

PROFILE Liberalism cannot survive without shared prosperity, says Nobel-winning economist Daron Acemoglu. Can we figure out how to divide the spoils? Or will ingenuity remain a mechanism for concentrating power? An interview **→P9**

Refined gains

CDSCO probes if rabies jabs fake after failed test

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NEW DELHI: India's drug regulator has traced a batch of the rabies vaccine Abhayrab, which it flagged as misbranded and not of standard quality after it failed a potency test, to an unlicensed batch in north Delhi from where police seized the vials in April, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) said on Saturday. Four people have been arrested in the case. The seizure is the second time less than two years that counterfeit Abhayrab doses have surfaced in India.

The public notice sets out for the first time where the doses of batch K25202 came from. On August 27, Drugs Controller General of India Rajeev Singh Raghuvanshi asked state drug controllers to alert their inspectorate staff and maintain strict vigilance over the movement, distribution and availability of the batch, a communication first reported by Reuters on Thursday. On April 22, the Crime Branch of Delhi Police, along with drug inspectors raided a flat in Mukherjee Nagar, and seized vials of the vaccine, the notice said. The regulator said no part of the batch was exported to any other country. **→P10**

At to explore gallium, lithium deposits within Kadapa basin

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HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh state mines department has begun the process of exploring valuable deposits of two critical minerals—lithium and gallium—identified in the Kadapa basin between Kurnool and YSR Kadapa districts, officials familiar with the development said.

Both lithium and gallium are considered strategically important minerals with wide applications in the battery, electric vehicle, electronics, semiconductor, aviation and renewable energy sectors. The Uranium Corporation of India Limited (UCIL) operates a project at Tummalapalle in Vemula mandal, where the Atomic Minerals Directorate for Exploration and Research (AMDR) has been exploring uranium reserves.

Earlier this year, scientists from the National Technical

Research Institute (NTRI) examined samples obtained from the area as part of their research. "Their preliminary analysis detected lithium concentrations of up to 1,000 parts per million (ppm) and gallium concentrations of up to 250 ppm in the samples," an official of the state mines and geology department said.

On August 12, the state government entered into a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the CSIR-National Geophysical Research Institute (NGRI) for extensive exploration of lithium and gallium deposits in the Kadapa basin.

NTRI will carry out the exploration, in collaboration with the state mines and geology department. The total cost of the project is ₹10 crore. The expenditure will be met from funds available under the National Mineral Exploration

ON AUGUST 12, THE STATE ENTERED INTO AN MOU WITH THE CSIR-NGRI FOR EXTENSIVE EXPLORATION OF LITHIUM AND GALLIUM DEPOSITS

Trust (NMET)," the official said. The official added that the Kadapa Basin extends for nearly 200 km, from the Vemula and Vempalli areas of YSR Kadapa district towards Kurnool district. Authorities have decided to undertake a comprehensive, four-stage exploration programme. The first phase will involve a detailed preliminary survey of the geological characteristics of the region. Scientists will examine the nature of the soil, water available in wells,

rock cuttings generated during earlier well excavation and soil brought to the surface during drilling operations. If the initial survey indicates the possibility of mineralisation, boreholes will be drilled at intervals of approximately 700 to 800 metres and samples of soil and underlying geological formations will be extracted and analysed.

If lithium or gallium deposits are thus confirmed, boreholes will subsequently be drilled at intervals of around 350 to 400 metres, followed by drilling at intervals of approximately 200 metres in promising areas. This will help scientists determine the size, grade and extent of the mineral deposits more accurately.

The final stage will focus on establishing the feasibility of extraction. Scientists will assess and recommend the appropriate scientific and technological methods that could be used to extract the minerals.

Preliminary studies by NTRI at Tummalapalle suggest an interesting geological pattern, with lithium occurring in the upper layers and gallium found at greater depths at the identified location.

"Based on preliminary assessments, the overall potential of lithium and gallium in the wider region could be as high as eight lakh tonnes. If confirmed through detailed exploration, the deposits could potentially be worth lakhs of crores of rupees, given the strategic and industrial importance of the two minerals," the official said.

Lithium is a key raw material for the manufacture of rechargeable batteries and has become increasingly important with the rapid expansion of the electric vehicle (EV) industry. Gallium, meanwhile, is used in semiconductors, radio-frequency communication systems and radar networks.



People, including DMK leaders, gather near former Tamil Nadu minister K.N. Nehru's home in Tiruchirappalli on Saturday.

Stalin hits out at DVAC raids on ex-minister

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CHENNAI: Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) officials conducted searches at premises linked to former Tamil Nadu minister and senior DMK leader K.N. Nehru across Tamil Nadu on Saturday, drawing criticism from party president M.K. Stalin.

Searches were underway in Tiruchirappalli, where Nehru's residence is located, as well as at premises linked to his brother, and in several other locations, including Chennai. A large number of Nehru's supporters, along with former minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi, gathered outside his residence. Nehru met them briefly and asked them to leave for the party office.

The searches were linked to alleged irregularities in the Gallium, and 25.28 per cent during Nehru's tenure as municipal administration and water supply minister, people familiar with the details said.

Nehru currently represents the Tiruchirappalli West Assembly constituency and is the DMK's deputy floor leader in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly.

The DVAC had earlier registered an FIR under Section 7(c) of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, and relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, naming Nehru, his brothers and several officials.

Strongly condemning the searches, Stalin on Saturday alleged that the state government was resorting to "purely politically motivated diversionary tactics" and the ongoing high court case and the Assembly session.



M.K. Stalin

In a post on X, the former chief minister said the searches were an attempt to intimidate the opposition.

He accused the ruling dispensation of engaging in horse-trading to secure power, a charge already denied by the TVK government.

"The people of Tamil Nadu are well aware that, to form the government, they induced MLAs from other parties to resign and inducted them into their party right on the Assembly premises," Stalin said, alleging that authorities had failed to register a preliminary inquiry into formal complaints filed in the matter.

Calling such actions the "dark side of Indian democracy," Stalin dismissed the government's moves as political "gimmicks" and said neither Nehru nor the DMK would be intimidated.

"We will confront and triumph over everything as per the law," Stalin said, asserting that the party would challenge the government's actions legally.

Responding to Stalin, state law minister R. Nirmal Kumar said the searches of Nehru's premises were a routine legal procedure based on evidence and complaints. "It is not an act of political vendetta, as alleged. No one has the authority to interfere with the functioning of the vigilance department," he told reporters in Madurai.

{ MURDER-SUICIDE BID SUSPECTED }

3 missing after family jumps into Godavari

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HYDERABAD: Search operations are underway for a 45-year-old man and his two children missing after a family of four allegedly jumped off a bridge into the Godavari in Andhra Pradesh's West Godavari district early on Saturday in a suspected case of murder-suicide, police said, adding that the man's 42-year-old wife was rescued from the water.

The incident took place at Chinchinada bridge on the river near Yelamanchilli mandal. "Local fishermen, who noticed the family members jumping into the river, rescued

the woman, but her husband and their 16-year-old son and 12-year-old daughter got washed away in the swirling waters," a police officer said.

Preliminary inquiries indicate that the family was incurring heavy losses in their businesses recently. "It appears mounting debts and pressure from creditors were the reason that forced the family members to take to the extreme step," the police officer said. He said the rescued woman was unconscious. "She was subsequently shifted to the Eluru government hospital for treatment. More details would emerge if she gains consciousness," added the police officer.

Passing out Parade at OTA Chennai



Newly commissioned officers in the Indian Army celebrate at the Passing out Parade at the Officers Training Academy in Chennai on Saturday.

Vijayan writes to Kharge over police action on SFI protesters



V.D. Satheesan

META RESTORES POSTS REMOVED FROM KERALAM CMO'S PROFILE

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan has written to AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge, protesting the alleged police assault on SFI students during a protest at University of Kerala and accusing the UDF government of adopting a "pro-union, anti-student" position, favouring right-wing groups.

In his letter, Vijayan said the students were peacefully protesting outside the university over the issue of singling the full version of Vande Mataram when police resorted to a "brutal lathi charge" without provocation.

He alleged that male police personnel assaulted female students and that no women police personnel were present at the spot, calling it a "serious violation of the law".

Vijayan said there had been a consensus since the first national movement to sing only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram to protect the country's pluralistic character and constitutional values.

He alleged that right-wing groups were now attempting to break the consensus, which had continued for more than 80 years, by making the singing of

the entire Vande Mataram compulsory.

"The Congress-led state government is also adopting the same position," he alleged.

Vijayan accused the Congress of adopting a "fascist" approach towards students in Kerala while opposing what he described as the repression of student protests by the Centre and the New Delhi police at the national level.

He said Congress leader Sonia Gandhi had expressed displeasure over the singing of the full version of Vande Mataram at the AICC headquarters.

"However, in Kerala, the Congress government is trying to appease the Sangh Parivar," Vijayan alleged.

He further criticised the state government's stand before the Congress, which he said could be amended in accordance with UGC regulations.

Vijayan alleged that by taking this position, the state government had accepted the Governor's "complete supremacy" over universities.

He said this was evidence of the state government's surrender to attempts by the Centre and right-wing groups to take control of universities.

Vijayan urged Kharge to intervene immediately and ask the Congress leadership in Kerala to withdraw from its alleged policy of appeasing right-wing groups and from using police force against students.

The protests were held on Tuesday in connection with an incident at Kerala University during National Sports Day celebrations, where the full version of Vande Mataram was sung.

The Students' Federation of India alleged that the programme was conducted in line with an RSS agenda and took out a march to the university headquarters in protest.

The organisation alleged that police used force against the protesters during the march.

The UDF government had earlier directed its departments to follow the Centre's instruction to sing the full version of Vande Mataram at Independence Day-related programmes.

STATE GOVT TO SCRAP NPS, REINTRODUCE OPS SOON: DY CM

BENGALURU: The Karnataka government will soon scrap the New Pension Scheme (NPS) and implement the Old Pension Scheme (OPS), deputy chief minister G. Parameshwara said on Saturday.

He said the reintroduction of OPS was a long-standing demand of government employees and also a promise made by the Congress party ahead of the elections.

"The chief minister has held discussions on the issue. The government has taken an important decision to scrap the NPS and implement the OPS soon," Parameshwara said, addressing a state-level Teachers' Day celebration organised by the Karnataka Sahitya Akademi and the Department of Literacy and Higher Education departments.

He said the OPS could not be reintroduced so far for certain reasons, but chief minister DK Shivakumar was scrapping the NPS.

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Keralam child rights panel to probe needle found in newborn's body

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KOTTAYAM: The Kerala Child Rights Commission on Saturday registered a case, while Kottayam Medical College appointed a three-member panel to investigate allegations that a needle was left inside the body of a newborn girl during treatment at the hospital in 2025.

Acting Chairperson Cicily Joseph registered the case, and the commission has decided to seek reports from the Kottayam District Police Superintendent and the hospital superintendent, an official release said in Thiruvananthapuram.

Kottayam Medical College has also appointed a three-member committee to investigate the incident, hospital sources said.

KOTTAYAM MEDICAL COLLEGE HAS APPOINTED A THREE-MEMBER PANEL TO INVESTIGATE ALLEGATIONS

The committee is headed by Medical College Deputy Superintendent Dr Frederic Paul. Dr R. Beena Kumar, Head of the Department of Gynaecology, and Dr Binny John, Head of the Department of General Surgery, are its other members, they said.

The committee will examine the allegations raised by the child's family in detail, authorities said.

According to the family, the needle was found inside the body of Anju and Vineesh's younger daughter nearly a year after her birth.

Anju gave birth to the child at Kottayam Medical College Hospital on June 24, 2025. The baby was admitted to the NICU on the second day after birth after developing fever and symptoms of jaundice. The family alleged that the needle was left inside the child's body during her treatment at Kottayam Medical College Hospital.

The needle was detected near the child's right ribs during an examination at Kozhikode Medical College Hospital in July 2026 and was subsequently removed through surgery, the family said.

IGW-AI data centre to come up in Hyderabad

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HYDERABAD: HyperVault, a subsidiary of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), will develop a large-scale artificial intelligence (AI) data centre campus with a capacity of up to 1 GW on more than 250 acres in Hyderabad, an official statement from the Telangana government said on Saturday.

A team of officials from TCS and HyperVault met Telangana chief minister A. Revanth Reddy at the state secretariat on Saturday. The chief minister described the project as "historic" for both Telangana and India, the official statement said, adding it marks a major investment in Telangana's emerging AI and digital infrastructure ecosystem.

According to the statement, HyperVault and its partners are expected to invest up to ₹70,000 crore in developing and managing the infrastructure, which will cater to frontier AI companies and hyperscalers. The project is estimated to generate around 7,000 direct and indirect jobs. At full build-out, the campus is expected to be among the largest and most advanced AI infrastructure campuses in India. The project will incorporate green energy and water-neutral design principles, according to the company.

The proposed campus is also expected to drive growth across several allied sectors, including power, cooling, networking, construction, engineering and data centre operations. "This establishes that Hyderabad is now at the forefront of the

A TEAM FROM TCS AND HYPERVAULT MET TGANA CM A REVANTH REDDY AT THE STATE SECRETARIAT ON SATURDAY

global AI revolution with a strong focus on infrastructure. This decade is one of Artificial Intelligence. Access to AI models and computers is fast becoming public infrastructure and having this project in Telangana gives us an advantage," the chief minister said.

IT and industries minister D. Sriharsha Reddy, who led the negotiations for the project, said the agreement reflected the state government's focus on speed

and clarity in facilitating investments.

"We tell the investors and corporations across the world, Telangana means business. We move at speed and with clarity of process that matches the expectations of the tech and corporate world," he said.

Sriharsha Reddy said the project originated from a conversation between chief minister Revanth Reddy and N. Chandrababu Naidu, Chairman of IITM, in June 2025. He said officials from the state government, HyperVault and TCS worked on the proposal over the subsequent months.

Telangana emerged ahead of five competing states to secure the proposed data centre project, he said. The state government

the HyperVault project would advance TCS' "Infrastructure-to-Intelligence" strategy by combining AI-ready infrastructure with cloud, engineering, enterprise transformation and AI capabilities.

"Hyderabad offers the scale, talent and ecosystem to serve global customers," Krittivasan said, thanking the Telangana government for its support and investment-friendly policies.

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Woman, son arrested over loans, 3 arrested

Letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Three people were arrested on Friday for allegedly abducting and confining a 36-year-old domestic worker and her son inside a room for two days after a dispute over loans, police said on Saturday.

The accused were identified as Sushanth Begum, 36, and her husband Sahal. A suspect identified as Saif is also under the scanner, said police.

According to the complaint, the woman had borrowed ₹50,000 from Nazath and agreed to repay it in weekly instalments of ₹5,000. She had also borrowed ₹1 lakh from Reshma about two years ago.

financial difficulties prevented her from making regular payments. On August 27, Nazath allegedly contacted the woman, offering her some paid work. She and her son were subsequently locked inside a house in Kumbalagode for the next two days and threatened and beaten repeatedly. She also alleged that Nazath threatened to harm her son and threatened to circulate a clip if the money was not repaid.

She also alleged that she was forced to sign certain documents without looking at them. Speaking to HT on Saturday, Chandra Layout police inspector M. Jeevan said that the woman's account was being verified and the accused were sent to 14-day judicial custody.

MY INDIA

Policy paralysis to dynamism in 13 yrs: PM maps India's growth

Snethi Sinha
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said India had moved from policy paralysis to policy dynamism in 13 years, returning to Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) to claim victory during the case he had made in 2013 from the same stage before he came to power. Modi last addressed SRCC in February 2013 during a business conclave, when his party was in opposition and he was a year away from national office. Speaking at the college's centenary celebrations, Modi said his 2013 address had set off a "wave", and attacked those who had pushed India into the "Fragile Five" and were now "unable to digest its 7.8% growth".

"India in 2013 was dealing with a series of challenges, including terror attacks, inflation and corruption. Growth was at its lowest and inflation was at the peak," he said. "Scams were at an all-time high, terrorists were fearless. Pakistan was aggressive at the borders and there was complete policy paralysis. The world was considering us in the fragile five nations. But now, if Pakistan even tries to attack, we respond with an attack. Nationalism has been rooted out and people are talking of policy dynamism."

The Prime Minister was addressing a gathering packed with students and spoke for close to 50 minutes. He returned to the analogy he had used in the collection of 2013. "I gave the example of a glass filled with water. Some people see the glass as half full. Some say it is half empty. I said there are people who can see the glass as fully filled — half with water and half with air. It was a time



Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacted with a child in the Delhi Metro on his way to the Shri Ram College of Commerce on Saturday.

when the country was lacking hope," he said. Critics who saw the glass half-empty then, he added, held the same view today.

Modi cited a 7.8% GDP growth rate in the most recent quarter and a ratings upgrade by a Japanese credit agency. "Achieving a 7.8% quarterly growth amidst the West Asia war and global trade hurdles demonstrates India's intrinsic capability," he said. Between April and June, he said, electricity production rose 9%, vehicle sales 20%, and steel and cement consumption 8% — evidence, he argued, of expanding confidence, housing and jobs.

He said his 2013 formulation of P2G — pro-people, good governance — had since been delivered. Referring to his independence Day address, Modi said: "From the Red Fort, I gave a homeopathic pill of 'Dimagi Naxal'. As soon as I said this, the Dimagi Naxals' began emerging one after another. Now their treatment will begin."

Modi, who took the Metro to the venue, traced SRCC from a sapling in Daryaganj to a major academic pillar, and peppered his speech with Gen Z terms.

The alumni of SRCC are, in your language, the OG. They may not be Dhurandars, but they have made an impact (Dhoom), he said.

"Today our youth can dream of launching a startup, building unicorns, entering sectors such as space and drones, building cutting-edge AI solutions and innovating in agriculture. Your seniors could not dream of these 13 years ago," he said, closing with a poem drawn from the college crest of a rising sun and a national emblem.

CONG ACCUSES PM OF POLITICAL MESSAGING AT DU'S SRCC EVENT

Pragati Chawla
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NEW DELHI: The Congress on Saturday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of using his address at Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) centenary celebrations for political messaging, instead of addressing students' concerns or engaging with those protesting over examination-related issues.

At a press conference, Congress-in-charge for student affairs Kanhaiya Kumar linked Modi's visit to the upcoming Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections on September 18, alleging that the event was aimed at benefiting BJP's student wing, the Abhi Bharatiya Vidharthi Parishad (ABVP).

"SRCC was not really created today, this programme must have been running since the beginning of time. One, perhaps to add to the half-full glass of positivity in the Prime Minister's glass through PR. The second is the Delhi University election. They may have gone there with the intention of benefiting their student wing in the Delhi University election," Kumar said.

He alleged that students had expected Modi to speak about issues concerning Delhi University, the education system and youth unemployment, but that these did not figure in his address. "He also did not discuss about students getting beaten at Jantar Mantar," he added. He alleged that students who wanted to attend the event were prevented from attending the event.

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Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Saturday removed Bhupesh Baghel as the general secretary in-charge of the poll-bound Punjab, replacing him with former Rajasthan deputy chief minister Sachin Pilot.

The party also appointed Randeep Surjewala as Gujarat in-charge, another state going to polls next year, shaking up the organisation ahead of the series of upcoming elections.

A total of three general secretaries have been allotted new states while another two leaders got dropped, according to a press release issued by party general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal.

The Congress has also moved its three most in-charges (apart from the general secretaries) to other states. A senior Congress leader remarked that this is one of the biggest reshuffles at the higher level of the party organisation.

Baghel, the former chief minister of Chhattisgarh, has been assigned Assam, where assembly elections will be held in April this year.

The Congress, according to two insiders, 'rewarded' Surjewala by giving him the Gujarat job, while he will continue to hold 'additional responsibility' as in-charge of Karnataka.

The reshuffle in Karnataka comes three months after DK Shivakumar was appointed the chief minister in June this year, replacing Siddaramaiah in a transition of power.

Appointed as Punjab in-charge in February 2025, Baghel's removal comes amid his strained equation with former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi, who has been demanding that party's Punjab unit chief Amrinder Singh Rajra Warring be replaced.

Channi had boycotted nearly all meetings chaired by Baghel in the past few months leading to an impasse that is affecting the poll preparations.

Last month, Baghel had submitted his report on Punjab to the party high command. It favoured no leadership change in the state. According to officials, Baghel was scheduled to meet Channi on Sunday for further meeting.

In his tweet, Channi thanked the party leadership for the "important decision".

"A warm welcome to Shri



Bhupesh Baghel and Sachin Pilot

Sachin Pilot, on his appointment as General Secretary in-charge of Punjab Congress. Heartfelt thanks to the Congress Party High Command for this important decision," Channi posted on X.

"Shri (Bhupesh) Baghel Ji has been a guide and mentor for INC/Punjab and all Congress workers in the state. His guidance has been instrumental in strengthening the party at the grassroots level. Personally, I have learnt a lot from him and will always remain indebted to him. Thankful for everything sir," Warring wrote on X.

He also congratulated Pilot for his appointment. "His energy and dynamism will be sure to add to the vigour of the party ahead of crucial assembly elections just a few months away."

Punjab faces assembly election in early 2027.

In September 2021, the Congress had forced then Punjab chief minister Captain Amrinder Singh to resign and elevated Channi to the post before the polls in 2022.

Baghel's removal also comes ahead of the proposed Punjab youth of Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi. Baghel had deeply involved in the preparations for the youth and held a meeting in Delhi last week.

"Gratitude to the top leadership for this new responsibility as the in-charge of Punjab. General Secretary of Assam Congress. Congratulations to all newly appointed General Secretaries / State in-charges. We, all Congress workers of Chhattisgarh, are grateful for the able leadership of Congress General Secretary, the esteemed Shri Sachin Pilot Ji," Baghel tweeted.

Pilot was handling party affairs in Chhattisgarh since the resignation of Channi. A senior leader from Punjab told HT, "We now expect Channi to attend election-related meetings. The equation should change. Channi, 48, is younger to the 63-year-old Channi. The reshuffle was necessary as Channi is the head of the campaign committee."

Pilot brings considerable orga-

nisation experience to the assignment.

He served as Rajasthan Pradesh Congress Committee president from 2014 to 2020 and as deputy chief minister from 2018 to 2020. As PCC chief, he led the Congress campaign in Rajasthan after the party's poor performance in the 2013 assembly elections and remained at the centre of the party's organisational revival that culminated in its victory in the 2018 polls.

"His immediate task is likely to be less about organisational restructuring and more about ensuring that the competing factions together in Rahul Gandhi Ji's proposed Punjab programme and the party's election preparations," said a Congress leader.

Meanwhile, Pilot said the upcoming election in Punjab would be an important opportunity for the party.

"I express my gratitude to the Congress President, the esteemed Shri@KJ Somaiya Ji, CPM Chairperson Shri@Sharada Jha, and the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Shri@RahulGandhi Ji for assigning me the responsibility of Punjab in-charge. The elections to be held in the state in the coming days are an important opportunity for us. Our goal and resolve is to move forward with complete dedication and loyalty and to bring the party to power. I am confident that through collective efforts, a strong organisation, and the hard work of the workers, we will strengthen the Congress in Punjab once again and pave the way for a return to power," Pilot wrote on X.

Congress MP Sukdhee Bhagat has been given the charge of Chhattisgarh Pradesh. He will handle Maharashtra affairs. PM Mohan, AICC secretary, is made in charge of Andhra Pradesh. Two general secretaries Jitendra Singh and party veteran Ram Chennithala have been named in the latest reshuffle. Tampi Naidu Kongares president, Manikam Tagore, who was in charge of Andhra Pradesh, has also been dropped.

Senior leader Mukul Wasnik will continue as General Secretary, AICC, Venugopal added.

(With inputs from Vishal Rambhai in Chandigarh)

Look beyond academic performance of students: Modi advises teachers

Sanjay Maurya
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi has urged teachers to look beyond students' academic performance and remain focused on their behaviour and everyday lives, particularly warning about drug addiction and excessive screen use. He also called on teachers to "preserve the innocence of childhood", nurture children's natural curiosity and instil the "dignity of labour".

Modi made the remarks while interacting with the winners of the National Teachers Awards at his residence at Lok Kalyan Marg on Friday evening, a day before Teachers' Day. The interaction comes at a time when teachers are increasingly being called

upon to address challenges affecting children beyond formal classroom learning.

This year, 82 teachers and educators have been selected for the National Teachers Awards. They include 48 school teachers, 21 teachers and faculty members from higher educational institutions and polytechnics, and 13 skill trainers from the Union ministry of skill development and entrepreneurship, according to a PMO release issued on Saturday.

The PMO said Modi emphasised that teachers need to look beyond academic performance and be attentive to changes in children's behaviour.

Referring to the gradual erosion of the traditional joint-family structure, he said teachers have an increasingly important

role in children's lives and should observe them closely, identify problems and provide personal attention wherever required. On drug addiction, Modi called upon teachers to remain alert to changes in children, identify the cause and help such children overcome the habit, according to the release.

The message puts greater responsibility on teachers to recognise behavioural changes early and help students dealing with harmful influences.

Modi also stressed that "preserving the innocence of childhood" is an important role for teachers. He urged teachers to speak to parents about how much time their children spend on screens and whether they continue using mobile phones late at night.

Teachers are frontline nation-builders: Prez

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: President Droupadi Murmu on Saturday described teachers as "frontline nation-builders", saying their role extends beyond imparting knowledge to nurturing curiosity, character, confidence and sensitivity among students, particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds.

"Watching films focused on the contributions and achievements of the award winners has further strengthened my belief that dedicated teachers are frontline nation-builders," she said, addressing the presentation of the National Teachers Awards at Vigyan Bhawan.

Murmu said a society that respects teachers is a progressive society and recalled her own experience as a teacher and student. She also congratulated this year's National Teachers' Awards recipients. She cited Radhinarayan Tagore's Shantiniketan and Utkalmani Gopabandhu Das's "Van Vidyalaya" or open school as examples of the belief that children develop naturally in the lap of nature.

Referring to the award winners, she said it was encouraging that a large number of recipients teach in village schools. Their teaching methods, she said, could inspire other teachers to pursue excellence.

Charge sheet against 13 in Pak espionage case

HT Correspondent
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LUCKNOW: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Saturday filed a charge sheet against 13 accused in a Pakistan-linked espionage case, alleging that they were part of a criminal conspiracy to spy on the country. The charge sheet names 13 individuals, including 10 citizens, 11 of whom are in custody, and 2 who are abroad. The charge sheet names Praveen Raj Vaidiki, Shiva Vaidiki, Ritik Gangwar, Sumeer Alias Shooter, Durgesh Nishad, Nausad, Gagan Kumar, Vivek, Shivraj, Meera Thakur, Shama Ram and Mahak.

The charge sheet was filed before the special NIA court in Lucknow. The case was earlier investigated by the Ghaziabad police and involves an alleged Pakistan-linked espionage network operating across the National Capital Region (NCR).

According to NIA, the accused conspired to commit offences prejudicial to India's sovereignty, unity and integrity. The agency said its investigation found that the

accused illegally trespassed into, approached and accessed prohibited and sensitive areas of importance and collected vital intelligence from these locations.

The accused allegedly installed spy cameras and transmitted sensitive information, including geo-tagged photographs and videos to the Pakistan-based spy agency, the agency said. The charge sheet named Praveen Raj Vaidiki, Shiva Vaidiki, Ritik Gangwar, Sumeer Alias Shooter, Durgesh Nishad, Nausad, Gagan Kumar, Vivek, Shivraj, Meera Thakur, Shama Ram and Mahak.

NIA also alleged that members of the network helped entities linked to the enemy state in procuring and using Indian SIM cards for unlawful activities. They allegedly assisted in obtaining photographs and videos of sensitive installations along with their precise GPS coordinates. NIA said the Ghaziabad police arrested 21 accused, and probe is continuing.

BJP MP NAMED L-G OF ANDAMAN AND NICOBAR ISLANDS

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: BJP Rajya Sabha MP Dinesh Sharma was on Saturday named as Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, the Rashtrapati Bhavan said.

"The President of India is pleased to appoint Dr. Dinesh Sharma as Lt. Governor of Andaman and Nicobar Islands with effect from the date he assumes charge of his office," the Rashtrapati Bhavan said in a communique issued late Saturday night.

Sharma, 62, earlier served as deputy minister of Uttar Pradesh. His Rajya Sabha term was to end on November 25. He is also the vice chairperson of the Rajya Sabha.

PAK LET TERRORIST YASIR KILLED IN J&K ENCOUNTER

Mir Ehsan
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SRINAGAR: Jammu and Kashmir Police on Saturday identified the terrorist killed in a high-altitude encounter in Budgam as Yasir, a Pakistani national and active Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) member. A hunt for another terrorist, Musa, continued in the area, but no special forces and additional reinforcements established a multi-layered cord across both sides of the mountain range to ensure all potential escape routes.

SOCIAL MEDIA POSTS PUT BALYAN FAMILY ON EDGE

HT Correspondent
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LUCKNOW: Threatening Instagram posts warning of 'big surprise' and blasts have prompted Shamli police to strengthen security for the family of slain Haryana singer Ankit Balyan, officials said on Saturday.

"Two days, 48 hours... big surprise!" Ankit's post says. "It's just the beginning! The blasts are yet to happen... if you want to see the blasts, stay connected with us."

The posts appeared on accounts carrying the name and photograph of wanted sharpshooter Santy Kadyan. Police are probing whether Kadyan operates the accounts or someone is using his identity. Shamli SP Narendra Pratap Singh said four additional policemen were deployed for the family's protection.

"Police are examining all the details of the social media activity, including whether the posts were made by Kadyan himself or by someone operating fake accounts in his name," Singh said.

Balyan, 32, was shot dead outside a Shamli gym on August 26. Police had earlier identified Aryan Sandhu as another wanted account in the case. Kadyan and Sandhu remain absconding.

CJ: Timely justice delivery can steer economic progress

NEW DELHI: A timely and predictable justice delivery system alone can steer economic progress of a nation. Chief Justice of India (CJI) Justice Sanjay Kumar said at the BRICS+ Chief Justices Forum in New Delhi on Saturday. CJI said the role of courts is like that of a "load-bearing wall" without which no building can stand.

Adani Defence signs 5-year ammo supply pact for AK-203

NEW DELHI: Adani Defence & Aerospace has signed a five-year agreement with Indo-Russian Rifles Pvt Ltd to supply indigenous produced 7.62x39 mm ammunition for AK-203 assault rifles being manufactured in India, creating an integrated domestic supply chain for the India-Russia rifle programme.

SAD MP Harisrart Kaur held during march to CM residence

CHANDIGARH: Shrimati Akali Dal (SAD) MP Harisrart Kaur Badal and MLA Ganiev Kaur Majithia were detained on Saturday when they were heading towards Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann's residence during their protest march over the 45 crore corruption case involving the CM's wife.

Fake Abhayrab anti-rabies vaccines seized

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: India's drug regulator has traced a batch of the anti-rabies vaccine Abhayrab, which it flagged as misbranded and not of standard quality after it failed a potency test, to an unlicensed flat in north Delhi from where police seized the vials in April. The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation said on Saturday.

Four people have been arrested in the case. The seizure is the second time in less than two years that counterfeit Abhayrab doses have surfaced in India.

The regulator's public notice sets out for the first time where the cases of fake K25012 came from. On August 27, Drugs Controller General of India Rajeev Singh Raghuvanshi asked state drug controllers to alert their inspectors to maintain strict vigilance over

the movement, distribution and availability of the batch, a communication first reported by Reuters on Thursday.

On April 22, the Crime Branch of Delhi Police, along with drug inspectors raided a flat in Mukherjee Nagar, and seized 1,100 vials. In the notice said, the vials were sent for testing, and the Central Drugs Laboratory (CDL) in Kasauli found it failed the potency test, which measures whether a vaccine carries

enough antigen to raise protective immunity. The test results also recorded that the vials were stored for storage between 2°C and 8°C, were being kept at room temperature when the sample was collected.

The regulator said no part of the batch was reported to any other country.

Indian Immunologicals Ltd (IIL), which sells Abhayrab, said in a statement that the samples were not sent for an enforcement action at an unlicensed residential premises in Delhi. "The same laboratory report revealed the artwork number difference between that vial and the retention samples of the same batch held at the laboratory, which we had submitted for batch release. On that basis, the vials examined are not a product manufactured by Human Biologicals Institute," the company said. Human Biologicals Institute of Technology is the IIL division that makes the vaccine.

Maratha quota activist refuses water, treatment

JALNA: Manoj Jarange-Patil's stir for Maratha quota entered the eighth day on Saturday, with the activist intensifying it by refusing to take water or medical treatment until his demands for the Maharashtra government had failed to implement assurances given to him.

Jarange, earlier in the week, had started to consume water and receive intravenous fluids following an appeal by a state government delegation, but he has now withdrawn his consent.

He refused medical examination by doctors at the protest site in Antarrasth Sarti, asserting that he would not accept any form of medical treatment until his demands were actually implemented on the ground. "Until the government implements all our demands on the ground, I will not take anything and will not undergo any treatment," Jarange



Manoj Jarange-Patil

told media here even as a medical team have attempts to persuade him to change his mind. "The Maharashtra government had assured him work on records pertaining to around 5.8 million Marathas would be initiated that he would not accept any form of medical treatment until his demands were actually implemented on the ground. "Until the government implements all our demands on the ground, I will not take anything and will not undergo any treatment," Jarange

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Ten convicted for 2013 ambush that wiped out C'garh Cong brass

Ritesh Mishra

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RAIPUR: A special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court in Chhattisgarh's Jagdalpur on Saturday convicted all 10 accused arrested in the 2013 Jhiram Valley Maoist attack, in which 29 people, including several senior Congress leaders, were killed. The court reserved the order on the quantum of punishment for September 16.

Special Judge Ajay Singh Rajput convicted the 10 accused, including two women, defence lawyer Arvind Choudhary said. During the trial, statements of 101 witnesses were recorded, the defence lawyer said. Eleven accused faced trial, but one died during the proceedings, he added.

The convicted accused are Pramila Modiyam, Chaitu Lekam, Sumitra Punem Modiyam, Mukka Mandavi, Kosa Kavasi, Aayata Markam, Madkani Sanna and Mahadev Nag.

"We will appeal against the verdict in the High Court. We have not received a copy of the judgment yet. We will be able to give the grounds for appeal after receiving it," Choudhary said.

The attack took place on May 25, 2013, when Maoists ambushed the Congress' Parivartan Rally on a national highway in Jhiram Valley in Bastar's Darbha area. Twenty-nine people, including Congress leaders, civilians and security personnel, were killed and more than 30 were injured.

Those killed included then state Congress chief Nand Kumar Patel and his son Dinesh, former leader of opposition Mahendra Karma, former Union minister Vidya Charan Shukla and senior Congress leader Uday Modiyar. The attack virtually wiped out the Congress' top leadership at the time ahead of the assembly elections that year.

The state police initially registered a case, but the then BJP government handed the probe to the NIA within two days. The NIA filed a charge sheet against nine arrested accused in 2014

and a supplementary charge sheet against 30 accused in 2015.

The verdict triggered a political row, with Congress saying the larger conspiracy behind the attack remained uninvestigated.

Former chief minister Bhupesh Baghel termed the verdict "incomplete justice", saying that convicting 10 lower-level Maoists could not amount to justice when the alleged larger conspiracy had not been probed.

"In such a case, sentencing only 10 lower-level Naxals cannot be called justice," Baghel said in a post on X.

He said the NIA had stated that around 200 people were involved in the attack and had named 39 accused, but only 10 were eventually arrested and convicted. Baghel also referred to a second FIR registered by Chhattisgarh Police in 2020 on a complaint by Jitendra Mudliyar, son of slain Congress leader Uday Modiyar, alleging a larger conspiracy. The Supreme Court had rejected the NIA's objection to the second FIR in November 2023, he said.

State Congress president Deepak Bagel also said the verdict was not justice for the victims, their families or Bastar, alleging that the attack was a political conspiracy to eliminate Congress leaders.

The BJP, however, welcomed the verdict and defended the NIA probe. BJP chief spokesperson and MP Santosh Pandey said the conviction would help bring the truth before the public.

"If you (Baghel) had evidence, why did you not present it before the court during your five-year government?" Pandey asked.

Deputy chief minister Vijay Sharma also questioned why the Congress did not act on its allegations when it was in power. He said the NIA probe had been found to be correct by the court, pointing out that the investigation was handed over to the agency when the Congress-led UPA was in power at the Centre and the BJP was ruling Chhattisgarh.

A decade-long political and legal tussle

May 25, 2013: Maoists ambush a Congress party convoy returning from a 'Parivartan Yatra' in Jhiram Valley (Bastar) ahead of the state assembly elections, killing 29 people.

THE ATTACK KILLED SENIOR CONG LEADERS

The incident disrupted the party's electoral machinery ahead of state assembly polls



HOW THE CASE UNFOLDED

MAY 27-28, 2013

NIA takes over probe, and the state government constitutes a judicial enquiry commission headed by Chhattisgarh High Court Judge Prashant Kumar Mishra

SEPT 25, 2014 - SEPT 28, 2015

NIA files a primary chargesheet against nine, followed by a supplementary chargesheet against 30 accused

DEC 2018

Following a shift in state power, newly elected Congress Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel announces an SIT to probe the attack, alleging that the central agency ignored a larger political conspiracy. The state DGP writes to NIA requesting a detailed probe report

JUNE 2020

The Congress party accuses the NDA-led central government of detailing the probe post-2014, pointing out that senior Naxal leaders (Gangpati and Ramanna) were declared absconders in March 2014 but omitted from NIA's September 2014 chargesheet

MAY 25, 2020

On the attack's 7th anniversary, a fresh FIR alleging murder and criminal conspiracy is filed against unknown people based on a complaint by slain leader Uday Modiyar's son

JAN 2, 2019

The state officially forms a 10-member SIT headed by IG Vivekanand Sinha. CM Baghel publicly accuses the Opposition BJP of fearing the SIT probe and accuses NIA of refusing to share case files

AUG 12, 2020

A Bastar Special Court denies NIA's application to take over the new state FIR

NOV 6-8, 2021

The Judicial Inquiry Commission hands its report directly to Governor Anusuiya UIkey. CM Baghel challenges this as a procedural violation, and notes that former head Justice Prashant Mishra had already been transferred

MAY 11, 2022

The Chhattisgarh HC stays the proceedings of the state's reconstituted judicial commission following a PIL filed by senior BJP leader Dharamlal Kaushik, bringing the probe into another legal stalemate

NOV 11, 2021

The Congress state government expands the judicial commission by appointing a new chairman and member, extending its term by six months

SEPTEMBER 5, 2026

A special court convicts all 10 accused, and reserves order on the quantum of punishment for September 16



Dy CM vs Dy CM: Manipur Kuki leader rejects colleague's claim

Prawesh Lama

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NEW DELHI: Manipur deputy chief minister Nemecha Kipgen has rejected allegations by her Naga counterpart Losi Dikho and eight other Naga MLAs that she and her husband were involved in the ongoing Naga-Kuki clashes, accusing them of making unverified claims that could further damage fragile inter-community trust.

On September 1, Dikho and eight other Naga MLAs wrote to Union home minister Amit Shah seeking action against Kipgen and her husband, alleging that they were colluding with Kuki militant groups and hampering the peace process.

"It pains me deeply that fellow elected representatives, including deputy CM Losi Dikho and other MLAs, would make such serious allegations linking my husband and me to attacks against Nags without first verifying the facts. At a time when families are grieving, communities are afraid, and the state is searching for peace, such accusations do not only hurt me personally; they also hurt the fragile trust that we are all trying to rebuild. These allegations are unverified and contradict everything I have done throughout this crisis. My efforts have always been focused on saving lives, regardless of community or identity. This is not merely a matter of public duty or constitutional responsibility. It is also a matter of conscience, humanity, and the value of every innocent life," she said.

She denied any involvement in the violence and said she had instead appealed for the release of those abducted. "On March 11, two Kuki-Zo civilians from Thawai Kuki village were abducted. In the effort to negotiate their safe release, 21 Naga travellers were detained by the local public. I made every effort to help secure their safe release and appealed to all stakeholders not to put anyone's life at risk. Tragically, the two Kuki-Zo civilians were killed, leaving behind grief that no family should ever have to bear. Even in that painful situation, the 21 Tangkhul Naga detainees were safely and unconditionally released. The Naga MLAs told



Nemecha Kipgen and Losi Dikho

Shah that Kipgen and her husband were colluding with Kuki militant groups and hampering the peace process. Her husband, Thangboi, heads the Kuki National Front, a group under the Centre's Suspension of Operations (SoO) pact.

"As for the allegation regarding violation of ground rules by SoO groups, their activities are monitored by the Centre and the state government under the tripartite agreement," Kipgen said. Kipgen also said she suspected a conspiracy, pointing to the escalation of Naga-Kuki clashes after she became deputy chief minister.

After President's Rule was lifted and a new government was formed earlier this year, the Centre ensured representation for all three major communities, with Meitei leader Yumnam Khemchand Singh as chief minister and two deputy chief ministers — Kipgen representing the Kukis and Dikho the Nags.

Kipgen took oath virtually from Delhi and is yet to visit Imphal because of security concerns. She currently operates from her office in Gangkopi. "I cannot help but wonder why Naga-Kuki tensions appear to have intensified so sharply after I became the deputy CM, especially when previous incidents have not resulted in this kind of loss of life between the two communities. Despite my best efforts, some groups have continually instigated violence targeting a previously peaceful Gangkopi district and me personally, even though I have done everything within my capability to help restore peace."

"These developments are deeply distressing because they distract us from what should matter most: protecting lives, healing communities, and restoring peace and normalcy in the State. At this critical



Nemecha Kipgen and Losi Dikho

moment, Manipur needs trust, compassion, and responsible leadership, not accusations that divide people further."

The Naga MLAs said they would be unable to continue supporting the Manipur government if the Centre did not act. At least 36 Kuki and Naga people, 18 from each community, have been killed since the latest clashes began in February, according to the unresolved Meitei-Kuki conflict that has killed at least 260 people and displaced 60,000. The MLAs also accused Kipgen of switching off her phone when Kuki militants abducted Naga civilians, six of whom were later found dead.

Kipgen rejected the allegation and said she was on a flight when the abduction took place.

"In moments of uncertainty, leadership must be guided by compassion, trust, and a sincere desire to protect every life. While the government is working tirelessly to restore peace, elected representatives carry a greater responsibility to speak with care and restraint. Words spoken without facts can wound communities, deepen fear, and make healing even more difficult."

"On May 13, 2026, when three innocent Kuki-Zo senior church leaders were killed in an ambush, the grief and anger on the streets were overwhelming. That painful moment led to the counter-demonstration of travellers from both communities. I was on a flight when the abduction happened. When I landed, I saw several missed calls and urgent messages. My first instinct was to immediately reach out to the CM and other stakeholders to help calm the situation."

"I personally appealed to CSOs and other concerned groups during the efforts that led to the safe and unconditional release of the 16 Naga detainees on May 15," she said.



Siya Goyal and Ketan Agarwal

ACCUSED'S FRIEND ARRESTED IN KETAN AGARWAL MURDER CASE

Shrinivas Deshpande

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PUNE: Pune rural police have arrested a third accused in the murder of Pune-based realtor Ketan Agarwal, 26, at the Lohagad Fort in June this year, officials said on Saturday.

Ritesh Hange (22), a friend of Chetan Choudhary, the alleged lover of Agarwal's fiancée Siya Goyal, is the third person arrested after Choudhary and Goyal. Hange, a resident of Beed who works for a private company in Pune, was arrested on Friday and produced before the Vadgaon Maval court, which remanded him in police custody till September 12.

According to police, Goyal (20), and Choudhary (22), allegedly pushed Agarwal off a cliff at Lohagad Fort on June 18, resulting in his death.

"During the investigation, it came to light that Ritesh was involved in the planning of Ketan Agarwal's murder," Pune Rural superintendent of police Sandip Singh Gill said.

Hange has been arrested for the alleged murder conspiracy, Gill said.

According to news agency PTI police said this emerged while examining a mobile phone seized during the probe, with chats and messages pointing to discussions about planning the crime and attempts to remove or destroy evidence linking the accused to the murder. Another police officer said Hange was involved in planning the murder with Choudhary and Goyal.

"He was aware of the earlier plan of Goyal and Choudhary to murder Ketan by breaking his hands and legs and subsequently eliminate him. After allegedly executing the murder at Lohagad fort on June 18, Chetan contacted Ritesh and informed him about it," the officer said.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Direct tax buoyancy above 1 for third FY

Saubhagha Chatterjee and Rajeev Jayaswal
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NEW DELHI: India's direct tax buoyancy remained above one for the third consecutive financial year in 2024-25 at 1.38, indicating that direct tax collections continued to grow faster than nominal gross domestic product (GDP), according to government data submitted to a parliamentary panel.

The tax buoyancy is a measure of growth in tax revenues as compared to GDP growth, showing responsiveness of tax revenues to changes in overall economic activity. Buoyancy value greater than one implies that tax revenue grows faster than GDP.

Direct tax buoyancy has remained comfortably above one in the last three years, rising from 1.27 in 2022-23 to a peak of 1.48 in 2024-25—“still well above one”—government said in a note prepared for the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance.

The government prepared the background note for the standing committee, led by BJP lawmaker Bhadrachari Mahab, which is currently reviewing reforms in the direct tax regime and their impact. The government has been con-

BUOYANCY VALUE GREATER THAN ONE IMPLIES THAT TAX REVENUE GROWS FASTER THAN GDP

stantly reforming the direct tax regime that included systemic reforms, ease of compliance and substantial reductions in corporate and personal income-tax rates.

In 2019, the government slashed the corporate tax rate for domestic manufacturing companies from 30% to 22%, and for new manufacturing firms from 25% to 15% to attract investments. The budget 2025-26 exempted individuals from paying income-tax for incomes up to ₹12 lakh under the new regime (effective exemption rose to ₹12.75 lakh for salaried taxpayers on account of the standard deduction).

In order to simplify the income-tax regime and make it contemporary, the government replaced the erstwhile 1961 income tax law with the Income Tax Act, 2025 from 1 April 2026. “Together, these reforms aim to enhance voluntary compliance, reduce administrative burden, and foster trust between

taxpayers and the government, ultimately strengthening revenue collection and economic growth,” the note said.

Commenting on some of the key reforms, the panel in its 13th report on the ministry of finance's demands for grants (2025-27) on March 18 said “strategic tax rate rationalization has yielded highly positive results”. Analysing data submitted to it by the department of revenue, it said this was evidenced by the gross tax-to-GDP ratio improving significantly from 10% in 2019-20 to an estimated 12.2% in the 2026-27 budget estimates (BE).

“This indicates that simplifying the tax structure has successfully widened the tax base and improved compliance. The Committee desires that the Government stay on the course of rationalization and simplification across both direct and indirect taxes,” it added.

Commenting on the upcoming rollout of the Income Tax Act, 2025, the panel said, it “presents a historic opportunity to further consolidate these gains. The Committee are of the belief that a stable, predictable and simple tax environment will invariably lead to sustained revenue buoyancy by transforming taxpayers from subjects of scrutiny into active partners in nation-building”.

SP LEADER BOOKED IN U.P. AFTER SEEN OFFERING NAMAZ AT CIRCUIT HOUSE

MEERUT: A Samajwadi Party (SP) district vice-president Haji Mohammad Usman has been booked for “obstructing public way and creating public nuisance” after a video of him offering prayers on the premises of the government-run circuit house in Moradabad was widely circulated online, police said on Saturday.

Police filed a case against Usman on Friday based on a complaint filed by the circuit house's in-charge junior engineer Anil Kumar, who alleged that Usman parked his vehicle on the road leading to the circuit house and offered prayers behind it on Thursday during a review meeting of SP leaders, police said.

According to officers, Usman offered prayers near the lawn. Ankit Srivastava, the Moradabad additional magistrate (City), said the district administration had received the official protocol concerning legal opposition in the legislative assembly Lal Bihari Yadav and arranged for his stay at the circuit house. During the period, a case came to light in which an SP leader who arrived to meet him offered prayers at the Circuit House. The administration is taking action in the matter.

Usman, however, rejected the charges. “This is a matter of worship. My offering prayers neither blocked any road nor caused any inconvenience to anyone,” he said.

8 killed as car hits truck in Keralam

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THRISSUR: Eight engineering students from Tamil Nadu's Dindigul were killed when their car rumbled into a lorry parked “illegally” on NH-66 in Keralam's Thrissur district, police said on Saturday.

The accident occurred around 11.40 pm on Friday at Panambilkunnu in Kaipamangalam, when the car, travelling from Guruvayur towards Kottayam, collided with the Maharashtra-registered lorry's rear, police said.

According to the FIR, the lorry was parked illegally on the right side of the highway near a barricaded stretch where traffic had been diverted as part of ongoing construction work. Police said the car was travelling at high speed and its driver apparently failed to notice the diversion barricade before the collision.

Six students died on the spot, while two others were declared dead on arrival at a nearby hospital, police said.

The deceased were students of an engineering college in Dindigul. Five of the deceased—Surya, Yuvasanjith, Joshua, Murali and Jeeva—were from Dindigul, while Santhosh and



A car collided with a lorry parked on the highway in Keralam's Thrissur district on Saturday.

Prasanna were from Madurai and Vishva was from Salem. Kaipamangalam police have registered a case against the lorry driver under Section 105 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for culpable homicide. The driver went into hiding soon after the accident, police said.

It is definitely a mistake on the part of the lorry driver. An FIR has already been registered. Additionally, regarding the highway authorities and the contractor, we will inspect that as part of the investigation and take strict action,” he told reporters. Following the accident, Kera-

was conducted at Thrissur Medical College, where relatives arrived to receive the bodies.

Thrissur Rural district police chief Mohammad Nadeemuddin said a preliminary investigation indicated the accident occurred due to the lorry driver's fault.

“It is definitely a mistake on the part of the lorry driver. An FIR has already been registered. Additionally, regarding the highway authorities and the contractor, we will inspect that as part of the investigation and take strict action,” he told reporters. Following the accident, Kera-

4 WORKERS KILLED AS BUILDING COLLAPSES AT PLANT IN MIRZAPUR

MIRZAPUR: Four workers were killed after a building at a stone crusher plant collapsed in Uttar Pradesh's Mirzapur district on Saturday, officials said.

The incident occurred at the SS Ranjan Stone Plant in Bhagwati De. The building, which housed the plant office, collapsed after its foundation ramp reportedly sank into the ground.

Chunar SDM Aneek Singh said four workers were inside the office when it collapsed and all of them died. The deceased were identified as Lal Bahadur (35), Ashok (38), Rakesh (28), and Duryodhan (28). Divisional commissioner Rajesh Prakash told officials to probe the incident.

lam chief minister Satish Chandra said he was “deeply concerned” over the increasing number of accidents and safety issues on National Highways in the state, particularly on stretches under construction. “Request Union Minister Nitin Gadkari to kindly accord high priority to a thorough safety review and immediate corrective action on NH projects in the State. Public safety must remain paramount”.

'Dahi handi' celebrations held; 2 dead



A participant breaks 'dahi handi' during 'Jannashanti' celebration in Gujarat's Ahmedabad on Saturday. In Maharashtra, however, a seven-year-old boy and a woman were killed and at least 130 'Govindas' were injured—118 in Mumbai and 12 others in neighbouring Thane city—during the celebrations, police said. The boy died in Mumbai after a brick column collapsed on him, while the woman was crushed to death under an iron frame in Pune, officials aware of the matter said.

LAST ACCUSED IN ILLEGAL CRACKER UNIT BLAST HELD AFTER ENCOUNTER

PRAVAGAR: The sixth and the last named accused in connection with the August 31 fire-cracker factory explosion near the Pravaggar-Kaushambi border in Uttar Pradesh was arrested following an encounter, police said on Saturday.

According to police, the accused, Shakeel, is the brother of factory owner and prime accused, Naushad. He sustained a gunshot injury during the encounter on Friday evening in Kaushambi, and later arrested, they added.

Circle officer (Manjhanpur) Saubhag Samant said joint teams of Manjhanpur police and the SOG took Shakeel into custody after an exchange of fire. A country-made fire-arm, one live cartridge, two empty 315-bore cartridges, ₹1,000 in cash, a phone and the motorcycle was recovered from him, police said.

UP collectorate mosque razed after court order

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MEERUT: A mosque inside the district collectorate complex in Uttar Pradesh's Saharanpur was demolished by the district administration on Saturday, days after a district court upheld an earlier order declaring the structure illegal, officials said.

The demolition was carried out amid tight security, with all five gates of the collectorate sealed and a heavy security contingent, including the Rapid Action Force, deployed to maintain law and order, they added. Saharanpur DIG Abhishek Singh said the city magistrate's court had found that the structure at the Saharanpur collectorate was illegally constructed on a government land. “The mosque committee's appeal was



A mosque, located inside the district magistrate's office complex, being demolished in Uttar Pradesh's Saharanpur on Saturday.

subsequently dismissed, paving the way for the demolition. Authorities had taken all preventive measures to maintain law and order and were strictly following established legal pro-

cedures,” the DIG said.

Dumsters and other demolition equipment were brought inside the premises on Friday night, and the removal of the mosque structure began the next

morning. Police and local intelligence unit had assessed the situation across the district ahead of the demolition, officials said.

The action followed a September 2 order of the district court, which upheld the decision of the city court on July 16, declaring the mosque illegal and imposing a penalty of ₹6.41 crore. The case dates back to March 24, 2025, when a petition was filed by Vikas Tyagi, the former provincial convener of the Bajrang Dal, alleging the structure was illegal. The mosque's sale challenged the court's order. The district court on July 20, 2026.

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav questioned the timing and manner of the demolition of the mosque, asking why the matter was not allowed to proceed to the high court or the Supreme Court.

BIHAR GOVT ISSUES NOTIFICATION ON CBI PROBES IN LINE WITH NEW LAWS

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PATNA: The Bihar government has issued a fresh notification on CBI investigations to incorporate provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, which replaced the IPC, CrPc and Evidence Act, officials aware of the matter said. The notification also reiterates that the CBI requires prior state government consent to investigate offences involving Bihar government employees.

The home department issued the notification on September 3, in “supersession of all previous notifications”. Officials said there was no change in Bihar's general consent allowing CBI to investigate central government employees, public sector undertakings and private individuals under the Centre's control.

The general consent given to CBI was never withdrawn in Bihar,” a senior state government official said.

Advocate general SD Sanjay said: “The notification has been issued for incorporation provisions of the new laws BNS, BNSS, Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam as well as provisions of old laws. Earlier notifications have provided for the old laws. This was essential for the official purposes in view of the new laws coming into effect. This was long due”.

The notification, issued under Section 6 of the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946, says prior consent of the Bihar government is mandatory when offences involve state government employees or persons working for corporations, companies or banks owned and controlled by the state, or institutions receiving financial assistance from it.

“Upon receipt of a proposal from the members of the Delhi Special Police Establishment, the State Government shall consider and decide on the matter of granting investigation powers on case-to-case basis,” it says.

A senior official said there was “no change in CBI's powers to investigate central government officials in Bihar”.

CBI officials also said the notification merely re-emphasised the existing arrangement for investigating state employees.

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

Some questions answer themselves, don't they?

Mononymous names, faraway places, astonishing animals and many interesting things in this weekly news quiz. Give it a shot

HT California, these cute but destructive rodents are terrorising hikers and stealing their shoes. In Colorado, a fuzzy fat father won the inaugural Fat _____ Week. Online, their OnlyFans page has helped raise funds for research. Which animal?

Amadeo Fusca won a \$100 grand prize for a local contest in NYC. He wore a Knicks jersey under his suit and a genial smile that reached his eyes. The person he was trying to look like is Mira's son, Rama's husband, and a mayor. Who?

King Rukidi IV of Tooro was the world's youngest reigning monarch. He was crowned at the age of three and ruled for three decades. Tooro lies inside a landlocked country in East Africa, bordered by Kenya, South Sudan, Congo and Rwanda. Which country?

Jatayu, who's been alone in the Delhi zoo for two decades, might soon get a mate. In the wild, his kind migrate annually from Africa to Europe and Asia. India has a resident population. A yellow-faced scavenger. A bird of prey. Who is Jatayu?

She was **Rosh** in a girl pop group. The band she launched her fashion brand in 2008. Her beauty brand, launched in 2019, just turned a profit. Maiden name: Adams. Her son Brooklyn is mad as her. Husband David isn't. Who?

The beaches of an Indonesian island go empty during Nyepi. People stay home, even internet use is down. Luzian Zraggen, a 26-year-

Natasha Rego

Answers on page 6

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DELHI S.I.R. CUTS

done by using Form 6 and deletion of names from Form 7.

But the number of those deleted between January 2025 and June 2026 is unusual when compared with previous exercises in Delhi. ECI data shows that the city's electorate increased by 0.4 million between the 2020 state assembly elections and the 2024 Lok Sabha elections and then again by 0.4 million people between the 2024 Lok Sabha elections and the 2025 state assembly elections, meaning additions were made more than deletions in the rolls.

Of the 1.1 million deletions, nearly 0.3 million were made between May 2026-June 2026 during the pre-SIR mapping phase.

Delhi's rolls listed 15,614,000 electors in January 2025. By June 2026, this number had fallen to 14,510,299. It now stands at 9,753,577.

Puja Devi, who works as domestic help in Nawada near Dwarka in South West Delhi, moved to Delhi 10 years ago after marrying Durgesh Kumar.

HT verified her voter ID, which lists Mubarakpur Dabas as her address.

In Adarsh Nagar, Baljinder Kumar said he has lived in the same house since 2010. By June 2026, this number had fallen to 14,510,299. It now stands at 9,753,577.

"I have been a voter in this area for over two decades. I was surprised that my name didn't even appear in the deleted voters' list. The BLO is now saying that I should register as a new voter under Form 6. But that means I am accepting that I have never voted before," Kumar said.

HT spoke to 15 residents across Okhla, Timarpur, Tughlaqabad, Narela, Rohini and Jangpura who described the same experience. They did not receive an SIR enumeration form because their names were already deleted before the exercise started.

Officials at the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office attribute the 1.1 million deletions to routine quarterly roll revisions and errors by BLOs. "Even though it's a high number, it's possible that these names were removed during routine revisions in that one year. BLOs might have also removed names during the pre-SIR mapping in May and June," a senior official said. "These people can get back on the rolls by registering as a voter using Form 6."

Some BLOs, however, insisted they were explicitly instructed from deleting names during the pre-SIR mapping window. During this period, they were only supposed to go door-to-door to identify electors whose names appeared in the 2002 rolls. These electors would not have to submit fresh documents, as their inclusion established continuity. For those born after July 1, 1987, parents' names in earlier rolls could help establish eligibility under the Citizenship Act, 1955, which reduces the need for additional documentation.

Jitendra Singh, a BLO from Narela, said additions and deletions were ordinarily processed through the year, but the pre-SIR phase was different.

"We receive applications for addition and deletion of names throughout the year. Even if we receive an application now, we will have to process it. In pre-SIR mapping, we are not supposed to delete any names. If a person is not found at the specified address, or if their names cannot be mapped to the 2002 list, we have to submit a report to our supervisors," Singh said. Jai Prakash, a BLO from Adarsh Nagar, echoed this. "We were told not to delete any names during the pre-SIR mapping. But routine revision was still being done. Some BLOs might have deleted names but that number should not be very high," he said.

Adarsh Nagar has the highest percentage deletion during this 16-month period—roughly a quarter of its 177,398 electors in January 2025. It was followed by Delhi Cantt and Uttam Nagar, where the electorate shrunk by 19.03% and 18.78%, respectively.

In absolute numbers, outer Delhi's Bawana recorded the single-largest fall, losing 69,112 electors from 384,849 in January 2025 to 315,737 in June 2026, an 18% drop. In Uttam Nagar, the number fell by 59,484 voters (18.8%), and in Nangloi Jat, 50,356 (18.7%).

CENSUS

February 10, 2022, with the model code of conduct having kicked in on January 8, 2022, the day the Election Commission announced the schedule.

The census will put 40 questions to every household, 11 more than in 2011. Question 10 asks respondents to declare caste in open-ended format, meaning enumerators record

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

what is stated without matching it to any prepared list. Others seek parental details, passport, Aadhaar, voter ID, driving licence and mobile numbers.

Among the four poll-bound states, caste arithmetic is seen as a particularly key factor in Uttar Pradesh and Punjab.

The notification, issued by registrar general of India Miryunjay Kumar Narayan, also advances the reference date for the four states—the moment at which the data collected is treated as valid—up to 00.00 hours on January 5, 2027. For the rest of the country it remains March 1, 2027.

Uttarakhand will be counted in two tranches. Its snowbound belt—131 villages and three towns across Uttarakashi, Chamoli, Rudrapur and Pithoragarh, covering about 52,000 people, according to the state census directorate—is being enumerated now, alongside Ladakh and the snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, where field work began on September 1 against an October 1 reference date. The rest of the state follows in December.

Census 2027 is the first to be conducted digitally, on a dedicated mobile application that works online and offline and a state census directorate—is being enumerated now, alongside Ladakh and the snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, where field work began on September 1 against an October 1 reference date. The rest of the state follows in December.

It added that during the insolvency process, Chandra said his net worth in 2024 was ₹31.79 crore and that "even in 2017-18, he did not have the net worth of more than ₹40,000 crore".

In its complaint, LICHFL said, "It is quite apparent that Subhash Chandra and the other accused persons have conspired among themselves with common criminal and dishonest intention to defraud the complainant".

The FIR also named Vasant Sagar Properties, its director Pankaj Suriyola, Pan India Infrastructure, Digital Subscriber Management and its director Amish Pandya, Spirit Infopower and its director Rujeev Dholakia and unknown others.

LICHFL said "Chandra had been acting in collusion with the borrowers Vasant Sagar, Pan India Infrastructure Pvt Ltd, Digital Subscriber Management and Spirit Infopower and their officers and directors defrauded and cheated LICHFL into advancing the loans to the borrower entities, which have since misappropriated the same."

It further accuses Chandra of creating "false documents to denote inflated and false net worth to cheat LICHFL into deploying funds to the Principal Borrowers".

CHANDRA BOOKED

Infopower and Multiventures Pvt Ltd as a co-borrower under a rental discounting facility.

A rental discounting facility, also known as lease rental discounting, is a loan against future rental income.

In both instances, LICHFL in its complaint said, the lending decisions were taken based on net worth certificates Chandra submitted in 2018 as his personal guarantee.

For the ₹500 crore loan, Chandra submitted certification saying his net worth, as on March 31, 2017, was ₹59.113 crore. For the ₹480 crore loan, Chandra gave a net worth certificate on July 6, 2018, stating that his net worth was ₹40,562 crore.

Both loan accounts defaulted and the current loss to LICHFL, according to the FIR, was ₹1,322 crore.

The CBI FIR said that during the subsequent personal insolvency proceedings, Chandra "categorically denied having the net worth as stated in the certificates," which he submitted to LICHFL to cause approval and disbursement of the loans.

It added that during the insolvency process, Chandra said his net worth in 2024 was ₹31.79 crore and that "even in 2017-18, he did not have the net worth of more than ₹40,000 crore".

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It further accuses Chandra of creating "false documents to denote inflated and false net worth to cheat LICHFL into deploying funds to the Principal Borrowers".

"The accused persons have publicly disclosed their intention to leave India and are likely to do so, unless a FIR is registered and investigation is undertaken at the earliest to trace the proceeds of the loans and assets of the accused persons", LICHFL said.

An officer cited above said, "We are investigating why he misled the creditor to avail the loans. Either he was lying then, or is lying now".

LICHFL is a party in the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) personal insolvency proceedings, in which the tribunal last month approved Chandra's repayment plan of ₹6.25 crore out of admitted claims of ₹22,006 crore. A five-member bench of NCLT later stayed this order.

Chandra, in a video statement last week responding to the NCLT repayment plan, said he had never personally borrowed money from the lenders. "There is no personal borrowing by Dr. Subhash Chandra from any of the creditors named in the order or from any other creditor/lender. He only signed personal guarantees," it said.

In the same statement he said he planned to work with a "friend in Switzerland." "Right now, I have a plan to work with my friend in Switzerland who does investment work. I will give you details of this in one or two weeks," he said.

"The current loss to LICHFL, according to the FIR, was ₹1,322 crore."

THE CURRENT LOSS TO LICHFL, ACCORDING TO THE FIR, WAS ₹1,322 CRORE

THE WEEK THAT WAS

ANSWERS

1. Marmots
2. Zohran Mandani
3. Uganda
4. A vulture
5. Victoria Beckham
6. Bali
7. Miley
8. Abraham Lincoln
9. Forbes
10. Ahimsa



Ashok K Lahiri

HEALTHCARE MUST BE READY FOR OLD POPULATION: NITI AAYOG VICE-CHIEF

Ridhima Gupta
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NEW DELHI: India's healthcare system must prepare for an ageing population and a changing disease burden, with the focus shifting from merely extending life to ensuring healthy ageing, NITI Aayog vice chairman Dr Ashok K Lahiri said on Saturday.

Speaking at an event at the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences (ILBS), Lahiri said the health challenges of future generations will be markedly different from those faced today. "The share of old people is going to increase and the health problems of the old of the future will also be different from what the young suffer today. The patient of tomorrow will not necessarily resemble the patient of yesterday," he said.

Lahiri noted that while India continues to grapple with infectious diseases, maternal and child health care challenges or undernutrition, the country is simultaneously witnessing a rise in non-communicable diseases.

"We have not completely overcome infectious diseases, maternal and child health care challenges or undernutrition. But at the same time, non-communicable diseases, diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, cancers, chronic respiratory diseases, obesity and metabolic and liver diseases are increasingly shaping our healthcare needs."

This means that the health system we design today must be prepared for tomorrow's older population. And if we do not age well, provision of healthcare services to the old may prove to be expensive. We need to age well," he said.

The vice-chairman also expressed concern over the indiscriminate use of medicines, particularly antibiotics. "Antimicrobial resistance reminds us that medicines that save lives today must remain effective for future generations," Lahiri said.

Isro staff bodies seek clarity on shift to pvt sector

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MUMBAI: Six years after the government opened the space sector to private companies, nine associations representing thousands of Isro employees have sought official clarification on the proposed transfer of the space agency's manufacturing and operational functions to private entities.

In a letter dated September 4 to Isro chairman and Department of Space (DoS) secretary V Narayanan, the associations sought clarity on the government's privatisation policy, Isro's future role, and the consequences for serving employees and future recruitment.

Employee bodies from several Isro centres signed the letter, which HT has seen. They include the Isro Staff Association, SHAR Employees Association, ISAC Employees Association, Isro Staff Association-IPSC, Isro Staff Association-BBU, NRSA Employees Union, Space Employees Association-IPSC and SAC Employees Welfare Association.

The associations wrote after Pawan Kumar Goenka, chairman of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPAC), said at a recent event that "eventually, Isro will not make any launch vehicles and will not manufacture any launch vehicles. That will all be done by the private sector or PSU."

The transition had already begun with the Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV), they said, and could extend to the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) and LVM3.

They also flagged reports about the proposed transfer of production of these launch vehicles, the movement of routine satellite manufacturing out of Isro and the opening of new launch infrastructure, including the Space Launch Complex at Kulasekharapattanam, to private entities. The letter referred to about 120 technologies already transferred from Isro to the private sector.

"These statements have received wide national publicity. They have not, however, been accompanied by any corresponding official communication from the Department of Space to its

THE LETTER ALSO REFERRED TO AROUND 120 TECHNOLOGIES ALREADY TRANSFERRED FROM ISRO TO THE PRIVATE SECTOR

employees explaining the approved policy, its legal and administrative basis, its phasing, or its consequences for the existing workforce and for future public recruitment," the letter said.

The associations said the prospect of Isro withdrawing from launch-vehicle and satellite production had created anxiety among employees and their families. Such a move, they said, could "tamper experiments after research, shrink in-house work, freeze or reduce sanctioned strength, and close promotion and skill-development avenues in technical, scientific, administrative, stores, purchase, quality, safety and industrial cadres".

"Launch-vehicle design, realisation, integration, testing and launch operations are not merely 'manufacturing contracts'. They are the core competence, institutional memory and strategic capability of the Organisation," the letter said.

Existing employees could become surplus, be redeployed or be left without meaningful work, the associations warned, and reduced recruitment to Group A, B and C posts could deny young people careers in Isro.

The employee bodies said they did not oppose private participation or legitimate commercialisation through NewSpace India Ltd (NSIL) within a defined framework. "The concern is the absence of an official DoS policy document that draws a clear line between enabling private participation and dismantling Isro's own realisation capability," the letter said.

The associations asked whether Goenka's remarks represented government policy, and whether Isro would remain responsible for the design, development, realisation, integration, testing and launch of PSLV, LVM3, SSLV and their successor vehicles.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

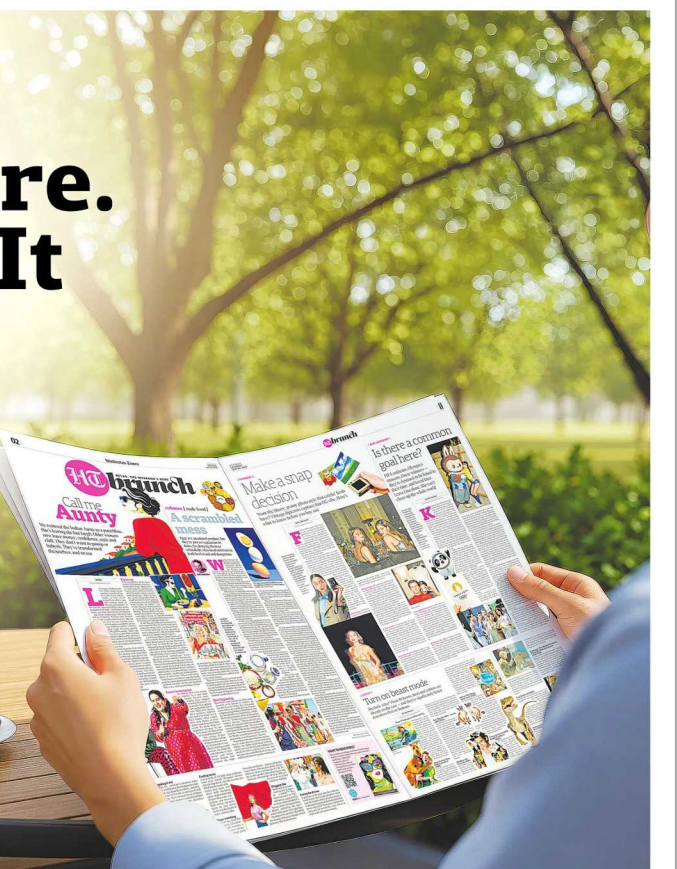
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{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

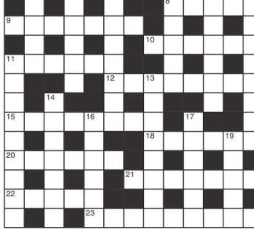
- 1 Feed a pet sugar perhaps (9)
- 8 Normally comes with two others, hips first (5)
- 9 Open with a play by GB Shaw (7)
- 10 Supply lines (6)
- 11 The way of a townsman (6)
- 12 The area isn't developed at all (8)
- 15 It's just between Canada and Britain (8)
- 18 Reformed ladies show the highest standards (6)
- 20 Cohere is upset but remains courageous (6)
- 21 Time to arrange up duty (7)
- 22 Grogginess in drink is confused (5)
- 23 Not solemn, perhaps just sleepy (9)

DOWN

- 2 A quiet craft by itself (5)
- 3 Tried a more orderly arrangement (6)
- 4 Filler makes a revolutionary jump (8)
- 5 Create chaos in a card game (6)
- 6 Dream I'm going round with a fabulous girl (7)
- 7 Realality means one looks for new interests (9)
- 11 The point of a savage attack (9)
- 13 Not saying much but understood on the vessel (8)
- 14 For about a pound a girl sees part of America (7)
- 16 Is included amongst those who are against rumours (8)
- 17 Craft in which wives seldom excel (6)
- 19 Discover Shakespeare's king has a point (5)

PUZZLE 17583

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1 Immediately upon looking (2,3,6)
- 8 Subtle (5)
- 9 Cover completely (7)
- 10 Obvious (6)
- 11 Commercial trustworthiness (6)
- 12 Very stupid person (8)
- 15 Living in particular place (8)
- 16 Dependable (6)
- 20 Link together (6)
- 21 Bent (7)
- 22 Scowled (5)
- 23 Push one's luck unduly (5,4)

DOWN

- 2 Purport (5)
- 3 Covetous (6)
- 4 Unsuccessful (8)
- 5 Regard as comparable (6)
- 6 Fault (7)
- 7 To the full extent (3,3,3)
- 11 King, queen or jack (5,4)
- 13 Flatter excessively (6,2)
- 14 Soothe (7)
- 15 Sweet-sounding (6)
- 17 Postpone (3,3)
- 19 Negotiate terms (5)

FRIDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17582)



{ SUDOKU }

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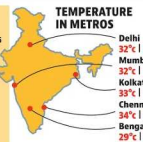
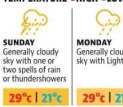
Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



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{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW



Ganga waters inundate Patna homes



A house lies partially submerged in floodwaters following a rise in the water level of the Ganga river crossing the danger mark at Nakta Diwara in Patna, Bihar, on Saturday. Several areas in rural Patna, causing disruption in rail and road traffic, while low-lying areas of the city were submerged. The disaster management department said that 252,000 people were hit by floods in Patna.

Eight new HC chief justices appointed

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Eight high court chief justices were appointed on Saturday, days after their names were recommended by the Supreme Court Collegium.

In a post on X, Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said Justice Valluri Kameswar Rao, currently a judge of the Delhi High Court, has been appointed Chief Justice of the Patna High Court.

Justice Sanjay Kumar Agrawal of the Chhattisgarh High Court has been appointed Chief Justice of the Bombay High Court.

A controversy erupted following serious, unprecedented allegations levelled against Rajasthan acting chief justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma by Supreme Court judge Sandeep Mehta, who in three letters to CJI Surya Kant sought the

JUSTICE SANJAY KUMAR AGRAWAL OF THE CGARH HIGH COURT HAS BEEN APPOINTED CHIEF JUSTICE OF THE RAJASTHAN HIGH COURT

immediate transfer of Justice Sharma and the appointment of a chief justice from another State.

Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra of the Punjab and Haryana High Court has been appointed Chief Justice of the court.

Justice Krushna Ram Mohapatra of the Orissa High Court has been appointed Chief Justice of the Chhattisgarh High Court. Justice Alpesh Yeshwant Kogge of the Gujarat High Court will head the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

FAMILY OF 4 JUMPS IN GODAVARI, WIFE RESCUED: POLICE

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Four members of a family allegedly jumped off a bridge in a suspected case of murder-suicide into the Godavari River in Andhra Pradesh's West Godavari district early Saturday, with a woman rescued while her husband and two children remained missing, police said.

The incident occurred at Chinchinada bridge near Yelamanchili mandal. "Local fishermen, who noticed the family members jumping into the river, rescued a 42-year-old woman, but her 45-year-old husband and their 16-year-old son and 12-year-old daughter got washed away in the swirling waters of the river," a police official said.

The family ran a grocery shop and milk business. "It appears mounting debts and pressure from creditors were the reason that forced the m to consider the extreme step," the police officer said.

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REFLECTIONS

{ THE BIG PICTURE }

Build a liveable India to realise the Incredible India potential

Clean streets, reliable transport, clear information and safe public spaces determine whether a visitor feels comfortable extending a stay or travelling beyond the main attraction

India's tourism potential is one of the world's great untapped opportunities. We possess the history, culture, biodiversity, cuisine and living traditions that travellers search for across the world. Tourism can create work across the country and bring foreign exchange into local economies. It can also carry India's story, values and way of life to people who may never have visited us before.

Over the past few years, Indians have rediscovered their own country in unprecedented numbers. The next task is to make the country ready to receive the world. That opportunity has become more urgent as India's aviation market expands. Being forecasts that airlines in India and much of this expansion will serve domestic and outbound travel. India must ensure that it also creates a stronger market for inbound tourism.

There is nothing wrong with Indians travelling abroad. A confident country should welcome that freedom. But the same aircraft, airports and air routes can bring more international visitors to India, if our destinations are ready to receive them. Otherwise, India risks building the connectivity to carry Indian spending overseas without capturing a proportionate share of international spending at home.

The biggest case for boosting international tourism is employment. Official estimates

based on the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) and the Tourism Satellite Account suggest that tourism supported about 84.63 million direct and indirect jobs in 2023-24.

The importance of these jobs lies in where they are created. Tourism can take employment beyond the largest metropolitan centres and connect local businesses to a much wider market. A visitor's spending reaches hotels and restaurants, but it also supports taxi operators, food producers, artisans, guides, homestays and small retailers. The World Bank estimates that small and medium-sized enterprises account for around 80% of licensed tourism and tourism-related businesses globally. A heritage town, a coastal village, a forest landscape or a craft tradition can therefore become the basis for local employment if it is connected to markets and managed well. Tourism gives states an economic use for assets that cannot be relocated.

The sector can also provide an important entry point for young people into the formal economy. Work in hospitality, food services, guiding and visitor management builds skills in customer service, languages, digital tools and operations that can be used across the wider services economy. The Tourism and Hospitality Skill Council estimates that the sector will require around 3 million additional workers between 2022 and 2028, creating a substantial opportunity for youth skill.

This is why the Economic Survey described tourism as a relatively low-hanging fruit for job creation at a time when technology is reshaping services and protectionism is making manufacturing more difficult. But the opportunity will be realised automatically. States will need to align training with actual demand, improve working conditions and

help local enterprises connect to hotels, travel companies and destination creators. They must treat tourism as a jobs strategy.

Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi's Independence Day address this year placed this opportunity in the right context, identifying India's soft power as the seventh stream of the country's development strategy. Promoting India abroad is, therefore, not simply an advertising exercise. It is one of the most effective ways to build soft power because visitors encounter India through its people, its heritage, its landscapes and its living culture. Those experiences travel back with them through conversation, media and memory.

That message now needs to be matched by a serious promotional effort. In the Union Budget for 2026-27, the allocation under Overseas Promotion and Publicity, including Market Development Assistance, was ₹3.5 crore. A Parliamentary Standing Committee

has noted that the entire amount is effectively committed to India's mandatory contributions to international organisations, leaving no meaningful allocation for international marketing. It described the absence of a dedicated promotional budget as a 'serious deficiency'. The ministry of tourism has reportedly sought ₹265 crore from the ministry of finance for promotional activities.

The Union government should create a ring-fenced promotional fund for international tourism, with resources large enough to support sustained campaigns in priority markets. Advertising and branding cannot be treated as an afterthought once infrastructure has been built. A destination has to be visible before a traveller considers visiting it. The campaign should be based on clear market research and should set distinct experiences rather than repeat a general slogan. India's



Amitabh Kant

{ SUNDAY SENTIMENTS }

Karan Thapar



Imran Khan as Munir's 'rock-hard place' problem

I can't claim Imran Khan is a friend but I've interviewed him on multiple occasions. In a cell, in multiple locations — at a hotel in Delhi, at his home in Bani Gala near Islamabad, at his hospital in Lahore and at his in-laws' estate outside London in Kingston. On each occasion, he was charming. You can't help but get attracted to the man. Usually, he speaks in a blunt and forthright manner but never offensively and certainly not rudely. But he always makes his point and leaves you in no doubt of it.

He also has a droll sense of humour. "Are you going to eat me up?", he asked when I last interviewed him. "Certainly not," I replied. "Why do you say?" "Because you did it on all the earlier occasions," he laughed loudly. "Doesn't it give you indignation?"

In those days, he wasn't the most popular politician in Pakistan. Today, he undoubtedly is. He's also been in jail for over three years and the Pakistan government seems determined to keep him there.

The charges he faces, for which he's been convicted, are trumped up. His real problem is he doesn't get with Pakistan army chief Asim Munir. When Imran Khan was Prime Minister, he had sacked Munir as director general of the Inter-Services Intelligence. Undoubtedly, Munir is getting his own back.

The major charges Khan faces are the Al-Qadr Trust case regarding land corruption, the Toshakhana case about illegally retaining and selling expensive State gifts, the Cipher case which is to do with sharing the contents of a classified diplomatic communication, usually despatched messages, with his relatives and, often, his doctors.

Not surprisingly, his health has suffered. His lawyers say he could have lost 80% vision in his right eye. Others say he has anxiety and blood pressure issues.

Last month, the Pakistan Supreme Court ordered Khan to be moved to a private hospital for medical examination and treatment within two days and stay there till September 16.

It allowed him to meet his family once a week and speak to his sons by phone in London twice a week. Twenty-four hours later, the government moved a review petition calling the order "discriminatory". It claimed Khan is "a convict and has to be treated in accordance with the law like any other convict." A day later, the Supreme Court registry returned the appeal deeming it incomplete.

This meant the government had no choice but to do as ordered by the court. It chose to act very differently. Instead, it took him to a State hospital late at night. Just a couple of hours. Neither his family nor his personal doctor were present when he was examined. By daybreak, he was back in Adiala jail.

This is surely contempt of court. More importantly, it is a further indication that the government is determined "to eliminate" Khan? His two sons, Sulaiman and Kasim, believe he will not survive his imprisonment in solitary confinement unless he's given proper medical treatment. It is that why it's being denied?

The mistreatment of Imran Khan can only add to his appeal and popularity. By its prejudicial behaviour the Pakistan government is enhancing his stature, not eroding it. Khan today is looked up to in a way he certainly wasn't when he lost power in 2022.

The problem in evaluating Hindu texts is that simplistic condemnation or exaggerated counter claims are both unwarranted.

contrary, the Hindu intellectual tradition is astonishingly plural. The *Bṛhadaranyaka Upanishad* recounts the episode where in a large assembly of learned men called by King Janaka of Videha, Gargi openly questions the most prominent and leading sage, Yajñavalkya, as does, later, the sage's wife, Maitreyi. In the *Mahabharata*, the fiery Draupadi bluntly asks Yudhishtira what right he had to put her on stake?

The *Satapatha Brahmana* states that a woman is half her husband. This is in conformity with the concept of *ardhanarishvara*, where divinity is depicted as androgynous — half male and half female. There is also the powerful feminine principle of *Shakti* goddesses who are not merely consorts, in some texts, the supreme cosmic power: women poets, saints and rulers are literary traditions in which women can be morally, intellectually and spiritually superior to men. The *Arthashastra* records that in Mauryan times, women could be bodyguards to the king, serve in the administra-

IMRAN KHAN'S REAL PROBLEM IS HE DOESN'T GET ON WITH PAKISTAN ARMY CHIEF ASIM MUNIR. WHEN HE WAS PRIME MINISTER, HE HAD SACKED MUNIR AS DIRECTOR GENERAL OF THE INTER-SERVICES INTELLIGENCE. UNDOUBTEDLY, MUNIR IS GETTING HIS OWN BACK

If anything should happen to him, like Caesar's sword, Khan will become more powerful and more threatening to the government.

If Khan alive worries Munir and Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif, Khan dead could very well paralyse them. That they're scared of his popularity and its consequences, is, perhaps, undeniable. Why then are they fueling it with their inexcusable treatment? I get the feeling they're creating their own nemesis. If they bring it on themselves many in Pakistan, who may be too cautious to speak today, will say they deserved it. Such is the fate of military dictators and their puppet prime ministers.

Karan Thapar is the author of *Devil's Advocate: The Untold Story*. The views expressed are personal

{ ENGENDER }

Lalita Panicker



Better data can help fund effective gender initiatives

Funding is a major sticking point for most efforts on gender equality. The government has adopted gender budgeting but it is spread over so many different areas that it is not nearly enough to bring about the needed changes. That said, different types of financing, from philanthropy to market-based capital and even grants, can be used to promote gender equality. But there are challenges that need overcoming. These issues were discussed recently at a panel on Philanthropy Opportunity: Designing the Capital Stack for Gender and Youth Empowerment, in New Delhi. Sudarshan Kundra, founder and director of Gender Sphere who addressed the panel, says, "The challenge is not only mobilising more capital for gender equality, it is making capital fit the change we are trying to create."

Often, grants and other resources are piecemeal and not enough to create the infrastructure and systems designed for long-term, gender-transformative changes. Most funders do not want to commit to long-term financing. At the discussion, this was a concern raised by philanthropists, funders and women's rights organisations.

Bain and Dasser's India Philanthropy Report 2024 shows that philanthropic collaborations established annually have increased nearly fivefold over the past three years, reflecting a growing interest among funders in working collectively to address complex social challenges.

Yamini Aravamudan, founder, The Southern Centre for Philanthropy and Impact, says, "In India, gender equality has historically accounted for less than 2% of CSR expenditure. At the same time, India's private philanthropy has grown to approximately ₹4.3 lakh crore in FY25, with family philanthropy contributing roughly 42% of that total. Private philanthropy directed toward development has reached a substantial scale, yet only 8% is identified as gender-specific. India is uniquely placed to help shape this agenda. We have

growing domestic wealth, increasingly influential family philanthropy, a dynamic social enterprise ecosystem, powerful women's funds and movements, and a generation of young leaders who are redefining both wealth and responsibility. The opportunity is not to import a model of gender philanthropy; it is to build one that is locally rooted, globally relevant and commensurate with the ambition of gender equality."

The lack of data makes pooling resources and partnerships difficult. Gender equality, the challenges of which vary between states, communities, classes, and even individuals, can't be addressed by just allocating a chunk of money to the problem. There are several examples which can be shared for the greater common good, many areas where funders and schemes can work together and build a sturdy ecosystem which can last. Of course, at all times, it is important to be in sync with government schemes and policies if for nothing but to avoid duplication of efforts. Targeted funding will yield much better results than scattered efforts.

Lack of data and information is not a uniquely Indian problem, though. In *The Lords of Poverty*, author Graham Hancock, once a UN employee, speaks of how misguided funding and aid, though well-intentioned, deliver little to no benefit to the end user. He illustrates this with an extreme example: A huge consignment of slimming pills going to war-torn Somalia where starvation was rampant at that time and refrigerators going to Sudan to areas which did not have electricity.

In many cases, one criticism has been that funding is given without taking into account the needs of the target women groups. Their voices have to be heard to channel resources and money in an effective manner. The funding and resources should be flexible and change as circumstances do.

The views expressed are personal



{ SUNDAY LETTERS }

Sanjay Chopra

Not a good look for men and society

This is with reference to "Judge work, not looks, of women in public life" by Namita Bhandare (Aug 30). People cross boundaries and leave no stone unturned in commenting on the looks of women irrespective of their work, status, and talent. Care needs to be taken when speaking publicly about women to maintain their dignity and give respect to their contributions to society.

Judgemental mindset with comments on looks of women is completely unbecoming for. Society must focus on the quality of their work & the proficiency they bring to the table.

Abhilasha Gupta

Anuradha Bisaria

Write to us at: letters@hindustantimes.com

Howknd

FOR YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

Daron Acemoglu

Refined gains

Can we figure out how to better divide the spoils? Can human ingenuity be used to work towards a greater shared prosperity; or will it always be a mechanism for concentrating power? What happens to liberalism if the outcome is the latter? In his new book, the Nobel Prize-winning Turkish-American economist explores some of these questions. Liberalism cannot survive without the dignity of workers, but AI – governed well – could help there, he says

Kanika Sharma
kanika444@gmail.com

Part of what makes Daron Acemoglu exceptional as an economist is the scale of the questions he is willing to ask. Much of his research sits at the intersection of economics, history and politics. Why do some nations prosper while others don't? What makes some institutions "good", and how does that affect prosperity? In 2024, he won the Nobel Prize, alongside fellow economists Simon Johnson and James A Robinson, for their work on how institutions shape prosperity, and how they in turn are shaped by the motives of those in power (motives that often involve profit). Their research took the shape of books such as *Why Nations Fail* (2012, co-authored with Robinson) and *Power and Progress: Our Thousand-Year Struggle Over Technology and Prosperity* (2023, with Johnson). His newest book uses a similar academic framework to explore the future of liberal democracy, and how it might be shaped by the future of work and AI. Acemoglu has been in the news lately, for a bit of a back-and-forth with *The Economist* about the nature of some of his views. There

is debate over whether he underplays the role of colonialism; whether his theories account for the rise of China.

What all sides can likely agree on is that a couple of fundamental questions now promise to shape our future: Can human ingenuity be directed towards a greater shared prosperity, or will it simply be another mechanism for concentrating power? What happens to liberalism if the outcome turns out to be the latter?

Acemoglu, 59, explores some answers in *What Happened to Liberal Democracy? Remaking a Politics of Shared Prosperity*. "Liberalism cannot survive without shared prosperity. It cannot survive without the dignity of workers," he says.

As we advance into an AI-fueled world, what does this mean? AI could help, if it's governed right, Acemoglu says.

But, "we should not presume that when it comes to such transformative technologies, the 'market' – or, in practice, a handful of tech companies – will make the right choices," he writes. Excerpts from an interview.

Given that liberalism had its greatest success when it had the support of key economic structures such as industrialisation – and given that it had that support because these structures depended on the participation of the working classes – do you think liberalism can make room for itself in a non-utopian technocracy?

Absolutely not. Democracy and liberal democracy in particular requires that people are not "dominated" by others in terms of economic or social power. People need to be able to look each other in the eye, regardless of their situation in society. This is not possible in a technocracy. Technocrats would have far more power over society.

Moreover, self-government, which is

equally crucial for liberal democracy, wouldn't make sense in a technocracy.

You write about liberalism's dilemmas, the first of which is intolerance. But is critical debate even possible in an algorithm-driven world?

It absolutely is. But not when those algorithms are controlled by the most powerful corporations humanity has ever seen.

This is why I argue that we have to regulate social media and AI.

The internet and social media could have been much more consistent with democratic discourse. That's what many people hoped in the late 1990s and early 2000s. The reason that did not become a reality isn't because compromise and dialogue are impossible online. It is because leading companies decided that wasn't what gave them profits and power.

You've said that good institutions can serve as game-changers. How would you define a "good" institution?

"Inclusive institutions" are those that provide incentives and opportunities for people to participate in economic activity on equal terms, engage in building human capital and undertake innovation.

Power and Progress and *What Happened to Liberal Democracy?* both emphasise that inclusive institutions also need to steer technology in order to ensure they are consistent with shared prosperity.

Why have such institutions traditionally been so scarce?

Building inclusive institutions is hard work. But more than that, many are designed by elites in order to be "extractive", so they get an advantage and monopolise resources and opportunities in the economy and have excessive power in politics.

Can inclusive institutions compete with machines that evolve as quickly as AI is doing?

Yes, and this is where I would call for a "proactive governance agenda for AI". This isn't regulation of AI in a defensive way. It's more about building a consensus on how society at large can benefit from AI and then building institutions to achieve that. The centerpiece of it is what I call "pro-worker AI".

Is pro-worker AI a realistic goal?

I believe so. But there is so much uncertainty about the capabilities of AI that I cannot afford to rule out that we will head toward something like artificial superintelligence (ASI), in which AI models, together with robotics, can perform every task and function that humans can, in which case pro-worker AI would be much harder or impossible.

I do not believe artificial superintelligence is imminent, which means there is room for pro-worker AI. But of course predicting the future of AI's implications for inequality isn't like weather forecasting. The future of AI depends on decisions that we as a society, and that the tech sector, make today.

I explain in the book why pro-worker AI could actually be profitable for companies as well. But it probably wouldn't be as profitable for big tech firms, because it would have to be more domain-specific and dependent on high-quality, often proprietary, data, which would necessitate a more decentralised model of AI.

Do you think it would help to redefine liberalism?

Liberalism still has the best ideas for our future and provides the best environment for us to deploy collective knowledge for our betterment. But liberalism cannot survive without shared prosperity. Liberalism cannot survive without the dignity of workers.

I think the most important element that I would emphasise is the relationship between liberalism and community. A fundamental mistake of current liberalism has been to sideline community.

What do you think we stand to lose, if liberalism fades? Many of the poor and working classes, for instance, seem content with more-closed societies, if these reflect their identity and protect them better. Who then are we fighting for liberalism on behalf of?

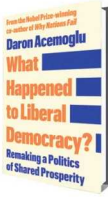
I believe that the working classes have this reaction because they have experienced liberalism in the form of social engineering imposed on them, and they saw liberalism as indifferent to their plight. Under different conditions, they were in the past, and can be again in the future, much more supportive of liberal ideas.

GETTY IMAGES

1 Daron Acemoglu, 59, is currently Institute Professor of Economics at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). His research, over decades, has sat at the intersection of economics, history and politics.

2 Born in Turkey, his father was a lawyer and lecturer at Istanbul University; his mother was a poet and principal at an elementary school. He first became interested in economics in high school, as he began to wonder about the links between dictatorship, democracy and economic growth.

3 Acemoglu later studied economics at University of York in England, and then at London School of Economics. He joined MIT as an assistant professor in 1993. In 2024, he won the Nobel alongside fellow economists Simon Johnson and James A Robinson, for their work on how institutions shape prosperity, and how they in turn are shaped by the motives of those in power – motives that often involve profit.



IN WHAT WAYS has social engineering been imposed on the working classes? What role, for instance, has education played? Read an excerpt from *What Happened to Liberal Democracy?* by Daron Acemoglu



We should not presume that when it comes to transformative technologies, the "market" – or, in practice, a handful of tech companies – will make the right choices.

inside



LIFESTYLE

Are we going to be the death of...

...the IBHK, the dinky hatchback? Once the stuff of middle-class dreams, these things are fading from view, replaced by brighter and shinier alternatives. This is, of course, something we worked towards and hoped for. We have gained and stand to gain still. What do we stand to lose? An essay by Ambi Parameswaran

on the web

The 30 best

It's been six years – and 300 editions – of *Wknd*. We're celebrating with a special that brings together 30 of our best stories. Ruskin Bond. Patrick Stewart. Elephants. Asterix... Check it out!



Are we
going to be the
death
of...

...the IBHK, the dinky hatchback? Once the stuff of middle-class dreams, these things are fading from view, replaced by brighter and shinier alternatives. The map of who spends most is changing too. New data suggests 100 cities – not five or six – will drive India's consumption journey. This is something we worked towards and hoped for. We have gained, and stand to gain still. What do we stand to lose? An essay by Ambi Parameswaran

Ambi Parameswaran
ambimqp@brand-building.com

It was a strange detail to notice amid news of a disaster, but it struck me because it held a mirror up to a fast-changing India. Fifteen Indians — 14 from third-party sales outfits and one company employee — were killed on July 11, when their sightseeing speedboat capsized off the island of Phu Quoc in Vietnam. The group was on an incentive vacation hosted by Indian smartphone maker Lava Mobiles.

The 14 top-performing distributors were from Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities in Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Kerala. The company sponsoring the gig was not an automobile giant or a cosmetics multinational but a homegrown electronics company. And the product was not a car or a two-wheeler but a mobile phone.

India's consumption dreams were born in black-and-white and stayed that way for decades.

Then, ahead of the Asian Games in 1982, the country transitioned to colour. About 170 low-power transmitters set up across the country allowed rural towns and villages to tune in to colour-TV broadcasts. Those transmitters can in fact be said to have triggered the first of many waves of consumerism in India.

A TV set became the first consumer durable to enter many homes (often even before a refrigerator).

Then came economic liberalisation, and the tsunami of capital, goods and investment. Cable TV, long before the internet, served as our link to a wider world. Foreign foods appeared in stores; we watched The

Bold and the Beautiful; movies were released here simultaneously with the rest of the world.

We wanted more, and the markets willingly complied.

Items that once required a waitlist now

became available straight out of the showroom: scooters, cars, big-screen TVs, two-door refrigerators, automatic washing machines. Tata ran an ad for its Indica that said: "50 cc moped, 100 cc mobike, 800 cc car. Now you can ask for more". And we did.

In the 1980s, a typical middle-class living room in urban India held a sofa and box-like TV, a showcase, dining table and often, not far from it, a refrigerator proudly on display.

By the 1990s, the TV had started to get bigger. No one was boasting about a fridge. And the new dream was a two-wheeler, or perhaps even a Maruti 800, parked outside.

Then came the internet, mobile phones, smartphones. As I wrote in this year's 10th-anniversary re-release of my book, *Nawabs, Nudes, Noodles: India Through 60 Years of Advertising*, About 350 million Indians had access to the internet in 2015. That number had crossed 900 million by 2025, and continues to rise.

India is the world's leading consumer of mobile data (it helps that prices are still so low here), and more than 600 million people in the country now watch streaming platforms.

It wasn't just that the internet offered direct access to the world, giving us a longer and louder list of material goals. The inter-

A new motorcycle, recent vacation, fresh hairdo... all became statements of purpose: This is what I'm doing with my life.

This has contributed to a change in how we see ourselves. Which brings us to the death of...

The IBHK, the hatchback, the simple family holiday in Kulu.

Is a IBHK something to brag about? Shouldn't it be two? And wouldn't 2.5 be better? Is a sedan something to drive to work in? When the couple next door just bought a small SUV?

Is a holiday in Kulu enough? Shouldn't it at least be Koh Samet... though of course Korea would be better (if only because it

As the landscape shifts, within a certain demographic, certain "old" products fade from view. Who builds a BRHK in a prime

The shift shows up starkly in studies such



HT ILLUSTRATION:
RAHUL RAKARATH

as the HCES (Household Consumption Expenditure Survey), which examines monthly per-capita expenditure (MPCE). HCES has been pointing to a shift towards non-food expenditure for about 15 years.

This is typical for a large and growing economy where food inflation is largely muted. Between 2011-12 and 2023-24, for instance, MPCE on durable goods rose from 4.85% to 6.34% of household expenses in rural India and from 5.60% to 6.83% in urban India.

Perhaps even more interestingly, this trend is not restricted to the top six cities. Aspiration has spread its tentacles more or less wherever the smartphone has gone.

A report titled *The Many Urban Indias*, by the thinktank PRICE (People Research on India's Consumer Economy) and Tata Sons, estimates that 100 cities — not five or six — will drive India's consumption journey.

In fact, the chart of per capita spending has shifted so dramatically, it has even redrawn the top spots.

Chandigarh and Thiruvananthapuram now top the per-capita household expenditure list. Vadodara, Surat, and Tirupur in

Tamil Nadu spend more per-capita than Bengaluru and Delhi. (Of course, the dramatic wage, income and wealth disparities in the latter cities explain some of that distortion; the richest in cities like Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru will still outspend the richest anywhere else in the country.)

This decline in demand for the IBHK and dinky hatchback (in certain demographics) is not, of course, all bad news. It's something we worked towards, as a country, and hoped would happen.

We of an earlier vintage remember dreaming our children would one day be confident and fearless enough to reason as they now do: "Why buy the entry-level car if a significantly better small SUV costs just Rs 1 lakh or Rs 2 lakh more?" or "Why not go for the 2 or 2.5 BHK? Friends can stay over, parents can visit comfortably, resale is more lucrative."

It's been interesting to see all this fuelled by a dramatically altered approach to borrowing.

Loans used to be a sign that something was either going very right or very wrong: a business was growing, a new house or car was in the works, or disaster had struck.

Today, a loan can be a matter of a shrug and a few clicks: taken for a holiday, that extra bedroom, new car, or to help pay for a wedding, honeymoon, new TV, air-conditioner, or phone.

E-commerce websites are full of even smaller and more whimsical products that can be bought on EMI: lamps, clothes, cosmetics, videogame consoles.

When the whole family participates in the excess, it can be hard to keep up.

I hope that doesn't bring us to the end of enough.

Indians have traditionally valued what we have. In some segments, I fear that that sense of enough may be fading fast. But that is an essay for another day.

Back to the IBHK, 100 cc bike and 800 cc hatchback car, these will likely always have

#1
India is world's leading consumer of mobile data

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Indians had access to the internet in 2015

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Indians had access to the internet in 2025

>600 million
Indians now watch streaming platforms

Monthly per capita expenditure (MPCE) on durable goods such as cars, recreational devices, air conditioners, furniture, etc. tells an interesting story. It jumped from...

4.85% of household expenses in rural India in 2011-2012 **to** **6.34%** of household expenses in rural India in 2023-2024

5.60% of household expenses in urban India in 2011-2012 **to** **6.83%** of household expenses in urban India in 2023-2024

AND FROM

100

cities across India, not five or six, will drive India's consumption journey, according to a report titled **The Many Urban Indias**, by the thinktank **PRICE** (People Research on India's Consumer Economy) and Tata Sons

culture

A neat hat trick

In youth protests around the world, an unusual icon has begun to appear over and over: a pirate flag, but with a straw hat thrown in. Check out its arc from 1990s manga to today



(Above left) In Indonesia in August 2025. (Above right) At Jantar Mantar, Delhi, in July. SHUTTERSTOCK, REUTERS

Bhanuj Kappal
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Two days after the police lathi-charge students as they tried to march to Parliament, I was in Mumbai, where a solidarity protest was scheduled. The atmosphere was tense. Police stood behind barricades; there were rumours about students being detained. Bands of teenagers milled about, uncertain which way to go. Eventually, as the crowd swelled, the mood shifted from wariness to power, with a hint of joy. Two boys marched by wearing matching Spiderman masks and chanting "Inquilab Zindabad" (Long Live the Revolution). Another, dressed as Superman, handed out roses to policemen and fellow protesters. And over and over I saw banners bearing what would, a few months ago, have seemed like an odd symbol: a black flag with a grinning skull and crossbones on it, the skull also sporting a straw hat.

The flag has been in the news repeatedly, over the past year.

In Jakarta, Indonesia, when pay perks and privileges for lawmakers (amid rising costs) sparked deadly protests last August, people hung it outside homes and on vehicles. In Nepal, last September, it was draped across the gate of the Singha Durbar palace, the seat of government, amid what was nicknamed the Gen Z revolution (prompted by corruption and mass unemployment, with the final spark being a social-media ban). It has also turned up in Madagascar, the Philippines, France, Peru, Mexico, the US, Bulgaria, Timor-Leste. And that was all just last year.

In 2024, it swept across Bangladesh, popping up seemingly overnight in street art across Dhaka, during student-led protests that took down the Sheikh Hasina government (the trigger there was a controversial jobs quota system, added to years of economic slowdowns and violent crackdowns against protesters). A year before that, it appeared for the first time in Indonesia, amid small pro-Gaza protests.

Piece de resistance
So what is this unusual version of the Jolly Roger or pirate flag?

It comes from the popular Japanese manga series One Piece, by Eiichiro Oda. It is the insignia of the Straw Hat Pirates, a crew led by a cheerfully anarchic captain named Monkey D. Luffy. Their search for a legendary treasure called One Piece sees the band of misfits go up against other pirates, bounty

hunters, criminal organisations and the authoritarian world government.

Since the first one in 1997, the manga volumes have sold more than 600 million copies globally (in over 40 languages).

An anime series based on the graphic novels has been running since 1999. There are also 14 animated feature films, videogame spin-offs, and an ongoing live-action TV series produced by Netflix (One Piece: 2023).

So when Gen Z (born between 1997 and 2012) hoists Luffy's flag, the protestors are drawing on a story they grew up with. The metaphor is not subtle. The Straw Hats sail into societies ruled by cruel or corrupt elites, knock over the people in charge and sail away again. In the Philippines, 22-year-old organiser Eager Vincent Liberto put it plainly last year. "We see the flag as a symbol of liberation against oppression," he told The Guardian.

Under one flag

There is a temptation to treat this as something peculiar to Gen Z, a sort of politics of whimsy. But protestors have always drawn on icons from popular culture.

In popular examples, the Guy Fawkes mask has been used by groups ranging from the Anonymous hackers to people protesting an era of digital surveillance. The white bonnets of The Handmaid's Tale have been used in women's rights and pro-choice marches. Demonstrators protesting Thailand's 2014 military coup began flashing the three-finger salute from The Hunger Games (where it is a sign that made news worldwide — simply resurfaced in subtler form amid fresh pro-democracy protests in 2020).

Meanwhile, such symbols are spreading at a speed not possible before the social-media age. There is no central committee deciding which icons to adopt, no manifesto on what a symbol represents, just a bottom-up adoption of symbols from a shared imagination. This allows the symbol to be both instantly resonant, and usefully fluid. An Indonesian truck driver angry about government spending, a Nepali student furious over corruption, and a teenager marching through Dhaka may not share the same political ideas. But they all recognise the heroes of the story: the group of rebels confronting a system that needs to be held to account.

{ NET GAINS } CURATE YOUR OWN FRICTION

Tap out: Step away from the screens, reclaim the real world

Sukanya Datta

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"It's gonna get easier and easier... and more and more pleasurable, to be alone with images on a screen, given to us by people who do not love us but want our money."

That was David Foster Wallace, author of the modern classic Infinite Jest (1996), talking to David Lipsky for Rolling Stone magazine, about the potential impact of the internet.

This was in 1996, and it turns out he couldn't have been more right. There is, of course, a magic to the seamless screens offer: taxis glide to the door, plumbers and electricians turn up as needed, groceries and meals arrive without a word needing to be exchanged. "Generations couldn't have dreamed up the luxuries we now treat as routine," says life coach Chetna Chakravarty.

What does it do to us, though, when we pay a premium so that we don't have to engage with people that once formed part of our community?

It frays networks, of course, that until a decade ago were still intact: the local taxi driver whose life story one knew; the shopkeeper who had watched all the neighbourhood children grow up; the electrician whose father had tended to fans and refrigerators in the area too.

Chakravarty argues that we don't have to lose it all. We can have a version of the best of two worlds. What would that look like?

Sometimes, pick the less convenient route

The human desire for small casual social interactions doesn't go away.

We saw this in the pandemic. Part of the void came from losing the momentary high we got from waving good morning to the security guard, chatting with the stranger in line for coffee, helping a new colleague work the printer.

A 2013 study analysed social interactions between a barista and customers and concluded that these casual interactions were vital, because humans "have a need to belong, and experience lower physical and emotional well-being when they struggle to fill this need". (The study was published in Social Psychological and Personality Science, and conducted by researchers from University of British Columbia.)

With so much of the friction ironed out of the day, some people are now craving a little of their own. In order to restore some of these interactions.

"I choose to sometimes go to the market, or to the local Chinese restaurant with the grumpy owner I've known for years, who still only grudgingly allows customisation," says journalist, author and entrepreneur Charles Assisi, who writes the Life Hacks column for HT WKND. "I also sometimes take an autorickshaw. Not because these are the most convenient options, but because I want to connect with people and support a different model too."

Start small. If this sounds appealing. Walk to the coffee shop near the office, instead of swiping and clicking online. Make this a habit. Even a few such interactions, a few times a month, can help set a routine, Chakravarty says.

Repopulate the inner circle

If there was a person on our contact list whom we hadn't met, it used to mean we didn't know them very well. That's changed, particularly since the pandemic.

We are likely now to have at least a few people in our social circle whom we talk to, confide in and may even turn to for help, but rarely meet or have never met in person. The apps made this possible, says Assisi. And it should translate to more social connection than before.

Sadly, that isn't how it tends to work out. Because the screen-centric relationships feel more effortless and demand less of us, we are more likely to make time for them over the people really in our inner circle.

In a loneliness special last June (scan the QR code below to revisit it), WKND talked to cultural historian Jay Bound Albert, author of A Biography of Loneliness (2019), about the effects of this. Interaction isn't the same as connection, she said.

The pandemic is over. We can reset the balance.

Set aside time for the inner circle, the cousins or school groups. The momentary high from an exchange of funny gifs may feel like a reasonable alternative. Numerous studies show it isn't. (There's more on this at the QR code too.)

Restore your right to choose

It wasn't meant to be the answer to everything: what to eat, where to shop, how to spend a few leisure hours.

It's easy enough to reclaim, from quick commerce, e-commerce and responsive algorithms, the right to really choose, and the joy of discovery.

Set the apps aside. Go to the supermarket or farmer's market and choose from options that haven't been optimised based on everyone's subscription plans.

Watch that niche documentary and learn something entirely new — like how loud the sun would sound, on Earth, if sound could travel through space (the answer is as loud as a jackhammer, all the time).

Make room for life's happy accidents.

Be present

This one is simple: Try to remember how rare it once was, to look away and start reading while someone was in the middle of a sentence.

We need to learn how to prioritise the people in the room, over the mini sound and light shows exploding on our phones. Try muting all alerts during free time, family time, meal times, or on that rare occasion when that group of friends has actually managed to meet.

Make the uncomfortable call, to someone you've lost touch with and really don't want to lose or the relative who called so often, until it became clear you had other things to do.

Make time for people. Make time for the self too. Go for a walk. Go to the dog park. Go window-shopping. Spend time being neither product nor consumer; just you.

Less is core: Are many of us simply doing self-care wrong? How can you do better? An essay by Ambti Parameswaran

(SOURCES: The Many Urban Indians, by the thinktank People Research on India's Consumer Economy (PRICE) and Tata Sons (2026); Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES) Internet in India Report 2025 by the Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI) and data consultancy company Kantar)



A still from the music video for the song 'Are You Lost in the World Like Me?' (2016) by Moby & The Void Pacific Choir. In it, screen addicts post selfies, send emojis or hunt for Pikachu, oblivious to the world around them.

READ 'Is it just me, or...?' How is it that we are both more connected and more lonely than before? A WKND special from 2025



a large market in an emerging economy like ours. Already, we are seeing those markets redistributed, as we transition from a bottom-heavy pyramid to a more pear-shaped society with a very large middle class. (Again, something we aimed for, and worked towards.)

It's not quite the yellow-brick road, though. Or maybe it is.

The challenge along the way will be for policymakers to ensure, through taxes, interest rates and levies, that the household debt burden does not follow the arc of aspiration and soar to untenable heights. This won't be easy, in a country so vast and varied.

Meanwhile, now that we're on this road, there is more or less no getting off it. And there is, of course, plenty to gain. As long as we don't get pulled in by the illusion at the heart of it all.

(Ambti Parameswaran is a bestselling author, advertising veteran and independent brand coach. His latest is the updated 10th anniversary re-release of Nauvab, Nudes, Noodles: India Through 60 Years of Advertising)

The chart of per capita spending has shifted so significantly, it has even redrawn the top spots. Chandigarh and Thiruvananthapuram now top the per-capita household expenditure list.

Dramatic wage, income and wealth disparities in the latter cities explain some of that distortion, of course. The richest in cities like Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru will outspend the richest anywhere else in the country. But the shift is notable nonetheless.

Vadodra, Surat, and Tirupur spend more per-capita than Bengaluru and Delhi.



{ THE SPORTING LIFE }

Rudraneil Sengupta

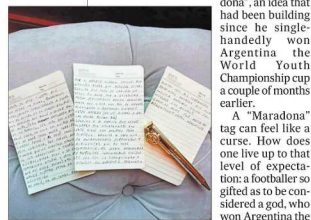
Score values

Isn't it strange that one of the greatest in the world at what he does can carry within him a sense of not having done enough?

When it was coming, but Lionel Messi's retirement from international football still feels momentous. The 39-year-old Argentine great posted the news on social media this week, alongside an image that evoked a different era: three lined pages, torn from a notebook, carrying an emotional note written in his neat, childlike hand.

In 2005, when he made his international debut as a floppy-haired 18-year-old, the first iPhone was still two years away. In his debut match, against Hungary, he lasted less than two minutes before being sent off for a foul that, today, would likely have seen the red card overturned by a Video Assistant Referee (VAR).

His two minutes were still enough for the world to declare the arrival of a "new Maradona", an idea that had been building since he single-handedly won Argentina the World Youth Championship cup a couple of months earlier. A "Maradona" tag can feel like a curse. How does one live up to that level of expectation: a footballer so gifted as he was considered a god, who won Argentina the



World Cup at 25, with a performance as dazzling as his (with five goals and five assists, he carried the team to its win).

In twenty-one years on, Messi hasn't just earned the tag; for many, he has surpassed his idol on pure footballing terms. Messi is the most-decorated footballer of all time, with 46 trophies, the highest assist provider and second-highest goal-scorer in the game's history; he has a record eight Ballon D'Ors, two Copa America titles (2021 and 24) and a World Cup (Qatar 2022).

But even the greatest among us can carry within them a sense of not having done enough. Messi's retirement note was a window to the vulnerable person behind the genius on the pitch.

"...retiring from the national team... is a decision that hurts my soul," he wrote. "I can say for sure that I always gave everything, not only in the last few years when we won everything [but] before as well, and I always fought and gave everything for the shirt, to give you joy and make you proud of being Argentinian through football."

Half of Messi's note is about him trying to prove he poured heart out on the pitch. "I love, have loved and I will always love being part of the national team. I have emptied myself: now I have nothing more to give," he wrote.

For more than a decade after his debut, Messi failed to do what Maradona had done: drag the Argentine team, over-reliant on his skills, to a World Cup triumph.

In 2016, when Argentina lost the Copa to Chile, it was the fourth straight defeat in a major final for the team.

A tsunami of criticism followed: he didn't care for his country, he only played well for Barcelona, was only interested in a shiny dividual glory, lacked the emotion and intensity that made Maradona great; they even claimed he didn't sign the national anthem with fervour.

Perhaps now, after two Copas, a World Cup and three World Cup finals, Messi can finally lay both the burdens and joys of wearing the blue-and-white colours to rest.

(Email Rudraneil Sengupta on rudraneil@gmail.com. The views expressed are personal)

Earth's own stardust

They are Nature's masterpieces: rare and finite. Natural diamonds are shaped deep within Earth's mantle, over millions of years, amid immense heat and pressure. It takes a violent kind of explosion to bring them close enough to reach. These glittering fragments of deep time also last forever, and so became symbols of eternity. What does it take to make one? It's a unique origin story

True Brilliance PART 1 OF 8



Arshia

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Of all the jewels in the world, there is a reason diamonds arrest the imagination so completely, and universally. It isn't just their brilliance. Diamonds resonate with something far deeper. They are a living manifestation of eternity. A symbol of the power of transformation.

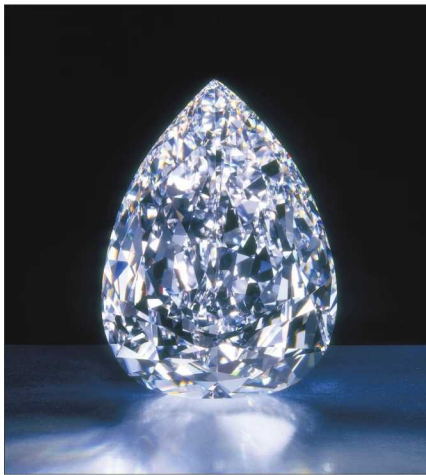
And of the power of time (as well as heat and pressure) to turn something ordinary into something, well, breathtaking.

Most gem-quality natural diamonds were already taking shape deep within the planet billions of years ago.

The oldest known diamond, found in Canada, has been dated to about 3.5 billion years ago. Which means that it survived over the course of three-quarters of Earth's history.

This is part of what makes these gems stunning records of deep time.

The colour of a diamond can be used by scientists to indicate the formation and residence history of a diamond. Yellow, for instance, is caused by the presence of the guest element nitrogen in the crystal. By analysing the arrangements of the nitrogen, researchers can approximate the amount of



time the diamonds would have resided at depths within the earth.

This is what one holds in one's hand when one owns a natural diamond: A cut, polished shard of the planet's deep past.

Fire and ice

So how do they form?

Unlike most gemstones, which crystallise near Earth's surface or within its crust, natural diamonds form deep within the mantle, typically at depths of 150 to 200 km, within the ancient nuclei of continents, known as cratons.

Within these cratons, it takes extraordinarily precise conditions, of an astounding nature, to create a diamond.

Most natural diamonds consist of carbon that has crystallised at temperatures of 900 to 1,300 degrees Celsius, amid pressures of 4.5 to 6 gigapascals or GPa (for context, the pressure at the bottom of the Mariana Trench is about 0.1 GPa).

The pressure deep in the earth where diamonds are born is so intense, it would shatter almost anything you could name: advanced materials used to drill through rock every known deep-ocean submersible. But this very heat and pressure cause the specific types of bonds that form diamonds, instead of graphite.

Each diamond eventually holds within it

Unlike most gemstones, which crystallise near Earth's surface or within its crust, natural diamonds form deep in the mantle, typically at depths of 150 to 200 km, in the ancient nuclei of continents, known as cratons. Within these cratons, it takes precise conditions, of an astounding nature, to create them

the story of what it has been through: the elements that were built into the growing diamond, the changes it encountered, and of course the heat and pressure. This is part of what makes each one unique.

So if you want to buy yourself something that, says, hats off for making it through a tough time, there's really no better symbol than a natural diamond.

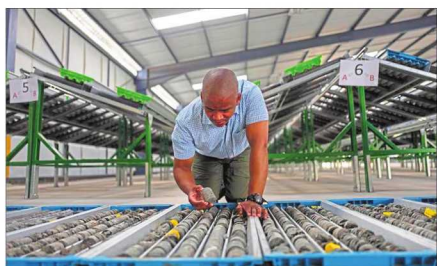
A bit of ancient Earth

What's interesting is that, after it forms, it takes a literal explosion to make diamonds accessible to us.

Even the most dramatic deep-drilling rigs today cannot reach further than about 12 km. Diamonds typically form at depths of 150 to 200 km. The only reason we can reach



(Clockwise from above) The colour of a natural diamond tells a story too; yellow, for instance, is caused by the presence of the guest element nitrogen in the crystal. A polished diamond is examined through a loupe. The 203.04-carat De Beers Millennium Star. (Below left) A worker examines geological core samples in a diamond-processing facility.



{ WITH LOVE }

Simran Mangharam

Do you really need to take the next exit?

Sometimes, we walk away from a relationship that works in almost every way – and regret it all our lives. It isn't that the reasons weren't real. But did they need to be a breaking point?

There are movies made about this. Two people fall in love, but still walk away, knowing they may never find a person so suited to them again. *Casablanca* (1942). *The Remains of the Day* (1993). *La La Land* (2016).

It's heart-breaking on screen, and even more so when this happens in real life.

There was no real reason for them to call it off, people say. In my experience, the reasons are real enough; they just needn't have served as a breaking point. Those are the saddest stories of all.

One woman living out such a tale is a 38-year-old client of mine, a lawyer; let's call her Rini. She fell in love with a classmate in their final year of college. Let's call him Kris.

They were a slow-burn kind of love. They interned at the same firm and that's where they formed a deep friendship. They realised there was true trust there, then affection, then intense attraction.

They embarked on a relationship, became inseparable, and remained so in the years after college. In something out of a modern-day fairytale, the two began their careers at the same law firm too. Both families were overjoyed when they announced, a year later, that they were moving in together.

By this point, friends and family had assumed this was it. They were a package deal, was the joke. Wherever one was, the other would be. Rini and Kris felt it too, the certainty of their love.

Their joy, friends laughed, was almost

annoying to be around.

Four years of living together brought them closer. They turned up at each other's parental homes on festive days, and in times of sickness in the family. They got to know each other's cousins. They learnt to have healthy fights, moving from bitter attack to measured argument, as many couples tend to do over time (a transition that does so much for the health of a relationship).

Then Kris began to discuss marriage, and Rini started to panic. It's too big a step, she said. She said it over and over, and he began to wonder what she meant. For the first time in years, they weren't on the same page. Eventually, the arguments stopped and a deep hurt set in.

The chasm proved unbridgeable. She was heartbroken. He was so bereft, he quit his job and moved to another city.

It has been 10 years since then. Rini has dated, on and off, but hasn't been in another serious relationship. She says she is still in love with Kris, and regrets following through on her decision to not marry. But a number of women are wary of this institution, she points out. They fear how it may change their relationship, and force them in predetermined directions.

Rini has seen this happen: I have too. Formalising their relationship, she argues, would have allowed a number of ideas into their lives that they had not accounted for. "I've seen people who lived together and were perfectly happy, as we were, the tie knot. And then expectations change," she says. "From family, from their spouse, even from themselves."

She still doesn't know if she and Kris would have been immune. But she is starting to wish she had tried.

I find myself wishing they had sought external help before calling it off. There are so many ways around such an impossible routine together and create your own rituals, marry but adhere to a pact of your own making. This is exactly the kind of situation where an experienced counsellor could alter the directions of two lives.

Fear of being consumed by a relationship, insecurity about change, a sense of being overwhelmed, are among the most common emotions encountered by relationship coaches and counsellors.

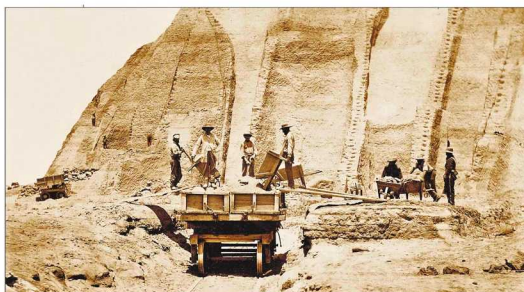
They can lead people to walk away from a perfectly healthy and loving relationship for reasons that may be very real, but might nonetheless have been fixable.

Once the damage is done, all we can do, as with Rini, is work through the grief, try to put the what-ifs to bed, and hope that another great love will come her way. It hurts to be at such a point with a client; I can't imagine how it must hurt her.

So I want to say, there is a better way. Talk to someone who is trained to help. There are no guarantees. It will all work out (there never are), but at least that way, you'll know you did all you could.



(Simran Mangharam is a dating and relationship coach and can be reached at arshia@bht.com. Jobin. The views expressed are personal)



A 200-ft mound of guano on the Chincha Islands near Peru, in 1865.

Millions of seabirds thrived here for aeons, undisturbed.

Their droppings became a key nitrogen fertiliser, as the world sought to grow more food. Where does dal fit in? It also boosts nitrogen levels in soil, and it's edible.

WIKIMEDIA

ADOBESTOCK

{ TRADE-OFFS } HISTORY, DRAMA, WAR: THE PULSES STORY - PART 1 OF 3

Never a dal moment

Mridula Ramesh

Nitrogen is remarkable.

That breath you just took is four-fifths nitrogen, but the gas does pretty much nothing to you or for you. Nitrogen in the air is essentially unavailable to living things. And yet, in a delicious paradox, all life depends on it.

It is a key player in how the molecules of life get built. It is part of every amino acid and every rung of our DNA.

Mediating this paradox – abundant but unavailable, scarce but necessary – is a bond. In the atmosphere, two nitrogen atoms clasp each other with a triple bond that is one of the strongest in all of chemistry. A bond so strong it literally takes a lightning bolt to break it.

Indeed, before organisms could crack that bond themselves, the only "reactive" nitrogen (a compound that life could actually use) on young Earth came from lightning, or from hydrothermal vents.

Then life caught on.

Eva Stueken, a geochemist at the University of St Andrews, UK, led research that measured nitrogen isotopes in rocks up to 3.2 billion years old, and found a signature – chemically consistent with biological nitrogen fixation. This suggests that the amazing enzyme nitrogenase, which replicates what

lightninging can do, but

at the molecular level, is at least that old.

Nitrogenase is a bacterial enzyme. So, for aeons, this method of nitrogen fixation was the domain of bacteria.

Then something changed. Plants got into the act, in cahoots with the bacteria.

By analysing the evolutionary traits of flowering plants, scientists have concluded that symbiotic nitrogen fixation arose in them a little over 100 million years ago.

Legumes show up not long after. Then, in the flux that follows the extinction of the dinosaurs, the fossil record suggests the legume family diversifies and spreads rapidly.

The partnership between plant and bacteria is mutually beneficial. The plant gets usable nitrogen delivered to its roots, while the bacteria get safe harbour and food.

But, the enzyme, a carryover from a bygone age, still doesn't like oxygen, and so the plant creates a special room for it.

On its roots, it creates nodules (left) with a chamber where a filter allows nitrogen in preferentially: what little oxygen gets in is rapidly consumed by the plant.

Here, the bacteria's nitrogenase breaks apart the nitrogen, essentially compressing lightning into a molecular space. Since this carries a huge energy cost, and it doesn't make sense to pay this cost when usable forms of nitrogen are available; indeed, experiments in legumes show that when a soil contains nitrate, nodulation is repressed.

The hero ingredient

In recent millennia, humans have caught on, partnering with plants who partner with bacteria.

Lentils and dals appear very early in the written and archaeological record. The latter suggests that mung, urad and tur originated in India, while chickpea likely did

(although it was found at Kalibangan, an Indus Valley site in present-day Rajasthan),

There is always a trade-off. Join me next time for more on the world of pulses, and on how Haber's gift helped sideline them.

The Vedas contain several references to these dals. One of Rama's favourite foods (still an offering on Ram Navami, the festival that marks his birth) is kousambi, a preparation of soaked mung dal and cucumber.

Dals appear in Sangam-era literature too, and in the 12th-century *Manasollasa* (Mins' Delight), written by King Somesvara.

By the time of 19th-century cookbooks, dals were everywhere. Lightly sautéed, in sambar, in the simple dal-and-rice, in vadas, dosas, idlis and other tiffin items, and in desserts such as laddoos.

Guns and bonds

As we began farming, though, settled agriculture posed a unique challenge: how to replenish the nitrogen, phosphorus and potassium removed in harvests.

While mulching and manuring helped, plants that could bring new nitrogen into the farming system became highly prized. Legumes, which had the added benefit of being edible, and crops such as *dhatura* (*Sesbania aculeata*) and sun hemp (*Crotalaria juncea*), became integral to agriculture.

Always, though, a sense of scarcity hung in the air.

As the 19th century dawned, the English economist Thomas Malthus began to issue warnings that the world's population would soon overshoot Earth's ability to provide, if something didn't change. A series of terrible famines, compounded by the brutalities of colonialism, claimed millions of lives and appeared to lend credence to his words.

In this century, a sort of gold rush began, as adventurers searched far and wide for new kinds of nitrogen fertilisers. The mid-19th century became the age of guano, the excrement of seabirds. The islands off the coast of the Peru were exceptionally rich sources of it. There were even wars fought over guano.

The guano market came crashing down in the early 20th century, as a German chemist named Fritz Haber found a way to break down the formidable bonds between two nitrogen atoms using very high pressure, high temperatures and a catalyst.

At the chemical company BASF, chemist and senior executive Fritz Bosch, a reserved man with a passion for collecting beetles, took Haber's laboratory-scale invention and developed the metallurgical and chemical engineering to scale it cheaply and safely.

Many hail the Haber-Bosch process as one of the greatest inventions of humankind, ahead of the microchip and electricity.

Bosch would win the Nobel for his work, in 1931. Haber, who won the Nobel in Chemistry in 1918, meanwhile, would go down as the hero who helped save the world from starvation, and the villain who invented chemical warfare. Such is the mixed legacy of efforts to feed the world.

There is always a trade-off. Join me next time for more on the world of pulses, and on how Haber's gift helped sideline them.

(Mridula Ramesh is a climate-tech investor and author. She can be reached at tradeoffs@rediffmail.com. The views expressed are personal)

US hits 3 Iran oil ships after warships targeted

Associated Press
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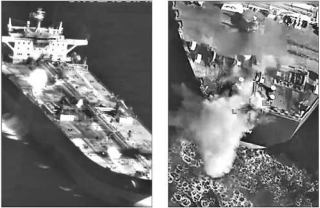
CAIRO: The US military on Saturday said it struck three Iranian oil tankers after Navy warships were targeted with missiles, warning that it would "if necessary, destroy Iran's limited and exposed oil fleet."

The strikes — a day after President Donald Trump sought to minimize the conflict as "small potatoes" — keep up a new tilt back toward fighting after six months of on-again, off-again war that began with US and Israeli attacks on Feb. 28. Both sides have sought to inflict both military and economic pain, and negotiations have collapsed.

The military's statement said a US aircraft carrier and a destroyer evaded "multiple unprovoked Iranian attacks" while patrolling in the region and no US personnel were hurt. It said two Iranian oil carriers were "permanently disabled" and the third, unladen one, was destroyed.

The US statement said the tankers were part of a shadow network helping to fund Iran's powerful Revolutionary Guard and its armed proxies in the region.

Earlier, Iranian state TV had



Screenshots of US strikes on the tankers.

U.S. CENTCOM-X

Trump backs Vance's claim on Iran war, calls it 'small potatoes'

WASHINGTON: Donald Trump said the conflict in Iran is "small potatoes" as he defended Vice President JD Vance for asserting that months of on-and-off attacks in West Asia are not a "war." Asked about Vance's comments made a day earlier, Trump said US strikes on Iran are now "intermittent" and "a lot of people don't call it a war."

said four US missiles struck a tanker about six miles (10 kilometers) from Kharg Island, home to a terminal through which the country exports most

of its oil. Kharg Island been repeatedly targeted during the war, including US strikes on military sites there in March. The US said one tanker was

struck off Kharg Island and another was struck near Jask, east of the Strait of Hormuz. The unladen tanker was hit in the Gulf of Oman. The statement shared what it called video footage of the strikes.

"We will not hesitate to defend American forces, and if necessary, destroy Iran's limited and exposed oil fleet," the head of US Central Command Adm. Brad Cooper said.

The strikes came nearly a week after the US and Iran resumed attacks following a month of relative calm, with the Strait and Iranian communities along it again being targeted. At least five people were killed earlier in the week during a US bombardment of southern Iran. One strike hit a wedding.

The resumption of fighting came after new US efforts to apply economic pressures on Tehran, whose hard-line new senior leaders have signaled the willingness to dig in after weathering decades of sanctions. Tehran's new leverage focuses on the Strait that is crucial to global oil and natural gas shipments and was seen as an international waterway before the war began.

The US military has been helping to guide ships through the Strait.

SINGAPORE POLICE PROBE RACIST AIR INDIA AND NEPAL FLOODS REMARKS

SINGAPORE: Singapore police are probing "shameful" racist and xenophobic comments posted online about the Nepal-Tibet flood disaster and Singapore Airlines' investment in Air India, senior minister K Shanmugam said on Saturday. He said the government would ask social media platforms to remove comments that breach their guidelines. "I have asked police to look into these comments," he said.

He cited several racist remarks targeting Indians and Singaporeans missing in the Nepal flash floods, including "I only see Indian faces here. Skip. Rescue cut." He said "ABNN", a derogatory term for Indians, was also used in one of the comments. He also linked the online abuse to renewed criticism of Air India after reports that the airline was seeking additional capital from its shareholders, including Singapore Airlines.

Nepal's army said a joint rescue team of Nepalese military personnel and South Korean disaster experts rescued the man from a 225-meter tunnel and that he was undergoing a health assessment. Images showed him being evacuated by helicopter, with an army medic checking on him during the flight.

A photo released by Chinese

2 rescued from debris after 10 days in Nepal

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com



The Chinese national (right) is rescued from the hydropower tunnel on Saturday.



Rescuers give water to a woman as she is rescued from her house on Saturday.

KATHMANDU: Rescuers in Nepal pulled out a Chinese man and a woman in separate operations on Saturday, 10 days after devastating floods hit the country, as teams continued searching for thousands of missing people.

The man was rescued from a hydropower tunnel, according to a social media post by the country's prime minister's office, bringing the total to three workers pulled alive from the Trishuli hydropower project. Two Nepalese workers were rescued on Friday.

Nepal's army said a joint rescue team of Nepalese military personnel and South Korean disaster experts rescued the man from a 225-meter tunnel and that he was undergoing a health assessment. Images showed him being evacuated by helicopter, with an army medic checking on him during the flight.

state broadcaster CCTV showed two rescuers carrying the man out of the tunnel.

CCTV shared audio of the man talking to an officer, saying how he repeatedly shouted whenever he saw the rescue crews' lights, but they could not hear him. "When they rescued me today, when they shone (the light) before my eyes, I couldn't believe it," he said.

Rescue efforts have increasingly focused on 12 hydropower projects across Nepal, where 900 workers are missing and roughly 500 are believed to be trapped in various tunnels.

In flood-hit Nuwakot town, a woman was rescued alive from a house. Nepal's army spokesperson said Saturday. Officials said she was airlifted to Kathmandu for treatment.

Lindsay Clancy killing kids trial ends in mistrial

PLYMOUTH: A judge declared a mistrial on Friday in the US murder trial of Lindsay Clancy for killing her three children, which her attorney blamed on postpartum psychosis. The declaration came after jurors sent notes were indicating they were

Greek jet crashes at annual aerial show, kills 2 pilots

ATHENS: A Greek air force jet crashed at an air show north of Athens on Saturday, killing the two pilots, officials said, as thousands of people were in attendance. A fire after the crash sent up a lot of smoke.

As AI decodes animal talk, experts fear it will be used against them

Agencies
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now hold a catalogue of 150,000 recordings, among the largest bird datasets anywhere.

NEW DELHI: AI is beginning to make sense of what animals say to one another, and some of the researchers driving that work now fear the same tools will give humans new ways to manipulate, exploit and hunt them, Bloomberg reported on Friday.

The report followed Vittorio Baglione and Daniela Canestrari, biologists at Spain's University of León who have studied carrion crows for three decades. In 2018 they fitted tiny microphones to the tail feathers of 43 birds and were left with thousands of hours of audio they could not analyse by hand. They borrowed a machine learning model from the Earth Species Project, and

Baglione told Bloomberg he had come to read one call, made when a buzzard attacked a nest and always followed by other crows arriving, as a summons for help. He said a hunter could use the same knowledge to tell a crow it was safe to approach.

That inversion is the field's central worry, César Rodríguez Garavito, who directs the More-Than-Human Life programme at New York University, in a 2025 report, set out scenarios in which such systems could expose animals to crowds of humans, be used for military tasks such as sea mine detection, or help capture and kill them. Twentieth-century whalers used

sonar advances to drive whales to the surface to be killed, and poachers use looped recordings to lure birds into traps.

Much of the dispute turns on playback, the practice of broadcasting recorded calls back at animals. It is the way of testing whether a decoded meaning is correct, and researchers said it can stress animals, disrupt their social groups and provoke conflict when the meaning of a call is not properly understood.

Kristin Andrews, a philosopher of animal minds, argued that decoding cannot proceed without something the animals will experience as two-way conversation, and suggested playback be confined to species that willingly seek out human company.

Putin meets US envoys, pauses strikes for 3 days

Agencies
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MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin started talks with US special representatives Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner at the Kremlin on Saturday, according to video published on the Kremlin's channel on the MAX messaging app, Reuters reported.

Putin described as "difficult"

the situation that he and the US envoys would have to address during the negotiations.

Earlier in the day, Putin ordered a 72-hour pause in strikes on Kyiv, the Kremlin said on Saturday, as Witkoff and Kushner arrived in Moscow to try to revive a stalled push to end the Ukraine war, AP reported.

"Putin has ordered that no strikes be carried out against Kyiv for three days, starting at

midnight today," presidential spokesperson Dmitry Peskov told Russia's Tass news agency. He said the decision was tied to preparations for Witkoff and Kushner's planned visit to the Ukrainian capital, which Kyiv has said will take place on Sunday.

Peskov also confirmed that Kushner and Witkoff would meet Putin during their visit, but said there was "no talk of new

ideas" to end the conflict.

The envoys' trip comes as both sides escalate aerial attacks, some 4 1/2 years after the Kremlin's invasion of Ukraine. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that Ukraine would halt airstrikes during the envoys' visit and urged Moscow to do the same. Washington's push to end the fighting, now in its fifth year, has lost momentum as the US focus shifted to Iran.

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India hammer Indonesia 14-0

MOOI: India made a commanding start to their title defence at the men's Junior Asia Cup hockey tournament with a 14-0 win over Indonesia in their opening Pool A match here. India women began their title defence with a 4-1 win over South Korea.

Anahat's run ends at London Classic

LONDON: India's Anahat Singh bowed out of the London Squash Classic after going down 4-1, 4-1 to Malaysian world No.5 Sivasangari Subramaniam in the women's quarter-finals of the PSA Gold event.

No plan to change RCB's name

MUMBAI: Reigning IPL champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru will retain their name despite the consortium led by the Aditya Birla Group acquiring the franchise in March, director of Aditya Birla Group Armaan Vikram Birla said.

Alpine's Gasly takes shock pole

MONZA: Frenchman Pierre Gasly snatched a surprise pole position for Alpine in qualifying on Saturday for the Italian Grand Prix at Monza, a career first in his 191st attempt.

Haaland keeps Man City on top

LONDON: New-look Manchester City overcame a spirited challenge from Coventry on Saturday courtesy of an Erling Haaland goal to stay perfect in the Premier League as blunt Tottenham Hotspur were held to a goalless draw at Nottingham Forest.

Satwik-Chirag storm into third final of year

Sandip Sikdar
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NEW DELHI: The Shenzhen Arena has become a venue of both heartbreak and triumph for India's premier men's doubles badminton pair.

On Saturday, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty unleashed their lethal attacking play and tactical acumen to ensure their latest chapter in the Chinese city would be one defined by resilience.

Returning to the gruelling international circuit after a frustrating injury layoff, the duo battled past Malaysia's Nur Mohd Azriyan and Tan Wee Kiong 21-16, 18-21, 21-10 in a pulsating 66-minute semi-final, their third successive victory over the world No.29 combine.

With the hard-fought victory, the fourth seeds booked their spot in the \$1.25 million China Masters summit clash for the third time in four years, hoping to finally cross the finish line after agonising runner-up finishes in 2023 and 2025.

The semi-final was a repeat of their entire Super 750 tournament interspersed with moments of vulnerability that tested the physical and mental mettle of the world No.5 pair. The match began on shaky ground for the reigning Asian Games champions. Starting down an early 9-5 deficit, they were momentarily caught off guard by the Malaysians' aggressive start.

However, displaying the tactical maturity that has made them world-beaters, Satwik and Chirag refused to panic. Instead, they orchestrated a scintillating seven-point blitz to snatch the lead at 7-5. Once they found their rhythm, their sheer power and court coverage overwhelmed the Malaysian pair, allowing the Indians to comfortably close out the opening game 21-16.

But Azriyan and Wee Kiong refused to fade away. Upping their speed and consistency, they forced the Indians into uncomfortable, fast-paced rallies in the second game, eventually edging it



India's Satwiksairaj Rankireddy (L) and Chirag Shetty in Shenzhen on Saturday.

21-18 to force a tense decider. For Satwik, this mid-match dip felt all too familiar, reflecting on the pattern with candid self-awareness. "This is the whole story of this week. We have been playing the first game easily, then the second game we are giving away in the 15-16 all (mark). It happened in previous matches too. But it is fine. It's a good tournament for us," Satwik said.

While dropping a game is never the objective, Chirag found a silver lining in their ability to weather the storm and recalibrate. "Anybody would want to finish it in two straight games. But I'm glad that we can actually, even after losing that second game, bounce back in the third and finish it quite comfortably," said Chirag.

The deciding game, as he put it, was a masterclass in domina-

tion. Leaving little room for the Malaysians to mount a second recovery, the Indian pair dictated the pace from the front court to the baseline.

Although Azriyan and Wee Kiong managed to save two match points in a last-ditch effort, the deficit was insurmountable. Satwik and Chirag sealed the decider 21-11, stamping their authority on the match.

Beyond the high of the win, this tournament serves a crucial purpose. Playing in only their second tournament after an extended break, reaching the final of a Super 750 tournament is a massive confidence booster. It is precisely the kind of high-stakes crucible they need before defending their Asian Games crown in Japan. Satwik emphasised the immense value of these pressure-cooker moments, which

cannot be simulated in practice drills. "We are coming back from injury. We wanted those crucial matches before playing the Asian Games. We want to get that feel, that confidence. Even when we are 16-18 or 18-11, we wanted to play these crucial matches... that kind of practice, we were missing," said Chirag.

This marks their third final of the year. Following a bitter loss at the Thailand Open summit clash in May, they bounced back spectacularly two weeks later to capture the Singapore Open, ending a frustrating two-year title drought.

Now, they stand on the verge of another crown in Shenzhen, a city Satwik admits has "been really special" for them. The duo will face world No.70 and home favourites He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu for the title.

Anand believes Gukesh can cope with pressure

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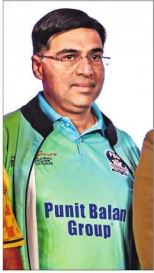
BENGALURU: You make the summit, win the biggest crown there is in chess at the ridiculous age of 18, only to be told: "Lovely, now do it again."

D Gukesh has the onerous job to do in two months' time. The defending world champion, now 20, plays Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov in an attempt to hold on to the title. His form since the World Championship two years ago has been worrying.

Five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand is in the unique position to understand what it feels like. "What Gukesh is experiencing, I've experienced a couple of times," Anand told journalists. "But he's experiencing it for the first time. You have no idea why the world refuses to work like it used to. You're working as hard as you think. You want it, you think. But the world is just not bending in the way it used to."

"The only thing I could tell him is that it comes with the territory. It doesn't matter what age you're dropped in the deep end of the pool. You will learn to swim fast. Or you'll splash around till you reach the surface and hold on to something. Maybe I was in a calmer place when I really got into crisis... I think he can cope."

Anand (PBG Alaskan Knights) began his Tech Mahindra Global Chess League campaign with a loss to Sin-



Viswanathan Anand.

darov (Fyers American Gambits) on the icon board on Saturday while Magnus Carlsen (Alpine APL Pipers) drew against Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (CheQ Mumbai Masters).

Anand spoke of undergoing "moments of shuddering halt" in his early 20s. "Even if I was slumping in classical, I would do well in rapid and feel good about myself again."

What worked for him when he was struggling was acceptance. "What I did was simply thinking, well, this is not what I envisaged, but this is where we are. The World championship starts in a week. I'm going to put my best foot forward there. I think it's also an appre-

ciation that you're not entered annually into the World Championship. There's a long runway to it. So that's how I dealt with it."

"I blocked everything out in Moscow (vs Boris Gelfand in 2012). I stopped thinking of it. But then, game seven happens." After six consecutive draws in the match, Anand lost Game 7. He went on to pull himself together, win Game 8 and later win the match.

"It's only with hindsight we plug it into the same pattern. Otherwise, every tournament is a fresh start."

Gukesh will play the Olympiad in Samarkand later this month, his final tournament appearance before the match. "Some unexpected gift in a tournament is all I need," Anand said. "Because in my mind, I'm not playing badly because I deserve to. In my mind, the universe is not cooperating. When I get lucky, I think, 'This is how it should be'. Self-deception is what we're good at. He could be incredibly happy with one game and that might change his mood. It doesn't matter. As long as you feel better, that's all that matters."

The crown can weigh heavy. Carlsen walked away from it. Ding Liren has nearly disappeared from the circuit, and Gukesh is seemingly caught in a conveyor belt of despair. "I don't know what it is... It's hard to maintain that consistency."

ISL to kick off on October 10

Press Trust of India
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NEW DELHI: The Indian Super League will kick off on October 10 and run through May 2027, returning to its traditional home-and-away format for a marathon eight-month league.

Last season, the ISL was played in a truncated single-leg format in a short window after being delayed by administrative and commercial uncertainty. The 2026-27 edition will be staged in a new club-led era,

with 163 matches scheduled across eight months of competition.

Churchill Brothers' participation in the upcoming season will remain subject to the club fulfilling the necessary regulatory requirements and securing the required approvals. They are set to replace Jamshedpur FC.

The ISL will return to the traditional round-robin, home-and-away format, with the team finishing on top of the table at the end of the league stage being crowned the Shield Winners, the official champions of the ISL,

besides earning a slot in Asian competition.

IWL to start on Oct 16
The new season of the Indian Women's League (IWL), the country's top-tier women's football competition, will kick off next month, the All India Football Federation (AIFF) said on Saturday. The season will begin on October 16 with six clubs from last season — East Bengal, Sethu, Kickstart, Nita, Gokulam Kerala and Garhwal United — joined by promoted sides HOPs FC and Juba Singha FC.

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A resurgence act at US Open

Tsitispas, Medvedev's smooth run to the fourth round has come as a surprise after their struggles

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MUMBAI: In the wide open men's draw of this US Open where four of the top 10 seeds tumbled out in the first two rounds, a couple of seasoned faces have brought about an unexpected touch of familiarity. Unexpected because one had plummeted to an eight-year low world ranking of 88 in June and the other had lost in the first round of an ATP 250 event a fortnight ago.

Stefanos Tsitsipas and Daniil Medvedev have plotted an impressive revival act in New York, entering the second week after solid third-round victories.

The Greek world No.53, a former No.3, overcame a slow start to beat 18th seed Czech Jiri Lehecka 2-6, 6-1, 7-6(3), 6-1 and knocked out another big fish, having stunned French 10th seed Arthur Fils in the first round.

Medvedev, the Russian ex-world No.1 who is still No.8 in the ATP charts but was hardly playing like one on the hard court swing heading into the Slam, brushed aside big-serving Frenchman Arthur Rinderknech 6-4, 6-4, 6-4. He has yet to drop a set.

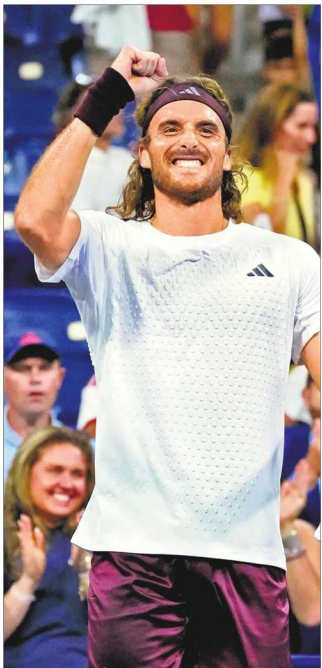
Tsitispas, 28, had won just five Slam matches in the last two years before this US Open. He has now made the fourth round for the first time since 2024, and the first time in New York. Medvedev, 30, had won six matches in the same period, and a solitary one last year. The 2021 US Open champion had now reached the fourth round for only the second time since 2024.

These are experienced, title-winning pros who collectively featured in seven finals and captured one Major through the dominant Big Three era. Both routinely flew into the business end of Slams, until they spiralled into a cycle of early exits. Both pressed for coaching shake-ups during the low phase. Both appear to be enjoying being on court a lot more now.

Far from rating about switching to pickleball mid-match last month, Medvedev, speaking on court after his win, joked about his struggles to conquer the new sport in tennis practice and her coach wondering where she gets it from.

Far from being stuck with physical and personal problems, Tsitispas spoke about starting a movement — "Keep OneHanderAlive" — in his on-court interview.

Tsitispas, in particular, has been in a whirlwind. A chronic back injury through a "very weird,



Stefanos Tsitsipas (L) and Daniil Medvedev have plotted an impressive revival act in New York.



REUTERS

KEY RESULTS (THIRD ROUND)

MEN: Daniil Medvedev (RUS) 7-6(3) bt Arthur Rinderknech (FRA) 2-6, 6-4, 6-4; Frances Tiafoe (USA) 11-9 bt Valentin Vacherot (MON) 6-4, 6-2, 6-4; Ben Shelton (USA) 6-3 bt Denis Shapovalov (CAN) 7-6(7/3), 6-7(5/7), 6-3, 6-4; Alex Michelsen (USA) bt Daniel Merda (ESP) 7-6(7/5), 6-4, 6-3; Tomas Etcheverry (ARG) 6-2 bt Mariano Navone (ARG) 6-4, 6-4, 6-3; Stefanos Tsitsipas (GRE) 6-1 bt Jiri Lehecka (CZE) 2-6, 6-1, 7-6(7/3), 6-1; Tommy Paul (USA) 6-2 bt Alexander Bublik (KAZ) 5-7, 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(4/7), 6-1, 6-3; Carlos Alcaraz (ESP) 6-2 bt Wu Yibing (CHN) 6-3, 6-4, 6-1.

WOMEN: Taylor Townsend (USA) bt Diana Shnaider (RUS) 6-2, 6-7(3/7), 6-3; Jessica Pegula (USA) 6-3 bt Leylah Fernandez (CAN) 1-6, 6-4, 6-3; Anna Kalinskaya (RUS) 6-3 bt Elina Svitolina (UKR) 6-3, 2-6, 6-3; Emma Navarro (USA) 6-2 bt Karolina Muchova (CZE) 6-7(3/7), 6-3, 7-5; Anastasia Potapova (RUS) 6-2 bt Anasimova (USA) 6-2, 7-5; Zheng Qinwen (CHN) 6-2, 7-5; Madison Keys (USA) 6-2, 7-6(3), 7-5.

way" last year, as he told the media on Saturday, meant he couldn't build any momentum. "It creates a lot of worry, and if it's around on a daily basis, it kills you. I stopped enjoying practice," he said.

Although he won the ATP 250 title in Gstaad in July, his results were also inconsistent this season (25-19 win-loss record). Tsitispas parted ways with his father, Apostolos Tsitispas, as coach again a couple of months ago, after accepting and rehiring him earlier.

The two-time Slam finalist brought up a Greek saying, which translates to "better late than never", explaining the decision. And with renowned coach Patrick Mouratoglou for company now, he came into the US Open carrying another ancient Greek saying in mind: prepare for the worst-case scenario. "I've already kind of embraced that there might be really bad scenarios. It won't always be ideal, the way I like it," Tsitispas, who plays American 8th seed Ben Shelton

next, said. "So going into a match with that kind of mindset allows me to view what I'm doing out there slightly differently than usual. Too much confidence can also kill your game. I've learnt that in different ways."

An unexpected Tsitispas is loving the feel of an underdog with lowered expectations. "It's fair to say that," he said.

It's also fair to say that not much was expected from Medvedev at this US Open. The former champion was seeded 7th alright,

but was one with three defeats in the previous four matches. After struggling with form last year, he too fired long-time coach Gilles Cervara.

This season's first half carried promise — he won titles in Brisbane and Dubai and made the Indian Wells final — before a second half crash. Medvedev again split with his coach, Thomas Johansson, and brought in Andrej Golubev for Cincinnati and New York.

Suddenly, Medvedev, who has dropped serve just once in three matches, is firing again. "Why? Because it's sport," he said. "This is normal for tennis, to have ups and downs."

The eloquent Russian also takes lessons walking around in other sports. Like baseball. "You see a great baseball player go through a tough period, and everyone feels like, 'Oh my God, he's done,'" said Medvedev. "And then, boom, for one month he's doing only home runs."

OLYMPIC CHAMP TO GRAND SLAM QUALIFIER, ZHENG TURNS IT AROUND

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MUMBAI: Qinwen Zheng was jealous of the players who always play on the bigger courts of Grand Slams. As a former Grand Slam finalist and the reigning Olympic singles champion, the Chinese had been there too. Not in the last few Slams, however, as her ranking nosedived after being away with a chronic elbow injury.

On Saturday, Zheng was back out there, as a qualifier taking on American Madison Keys on Grandstand, the US Open's third biggest court. And she scripted one of the week's biggest turnarounds, erasing a 5-0 deficit in the deciding set to stun Keys 1-6, 7-6(3), 7-5 in the third round. At 5-0 down, Zheng found her hitting range again, and Keys lost her first serves.

Turnarounds have been the theme for Zheng in New York. The last time she won six straight matches was during her gold-winning run at the Paris Olympics two years ago.

The 22-year-old 2024 Australian Open runner-up, who was world No.4 mid last year, is currently ranked 121st. That's a big fall for a former top-5 pro. Also a big fall? Playing the qualifying rounds to get into this US Open as a two-time quarter-finalist.

But she did, winning three matches and falling on the court — typically a Slam-winning celebration — after the third qualifier. Going from playing on the biggest courts to the smallest ones wasn't easy. "I spoke with my team, and my coach told me, 'Okay, this is what you have. This is your ranking. You need to fight like it's the beginning of your career,'" Zheng said after her second-round win.

Playing with persistent pain on her right elbow last year, Zheng underwent surgery in July. She returned in September, but stepped away again. "The second time I came back, it was hard, because I totally lost the dynamic of how to compete as an athlete," said Zheng.

She has found that in this US Open. As well as her presence on a big court again.

Anisimova out
On Louis Armstrong, Amanda Anisimova, the 10th seeded American and last year's runner-up, was stunned by Anastasia Potapova 6-2, 7-5.

In the men's draw, Carlos Alcaraz continued to motor along with a 6-3, 6-4, 6-1 victory over China's Wu Yibing in the third round.



Sree Charani (L) with Harmanpreet Kaur on Saturday.

BCCLX

Spinners rule as India brush aside Pakistan

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NEW DELHI: On a pitch offering grip and turn, India's spinners gave Pakistan nowhere to hide as Harmanpreet Kaur and Co won by seven wickets.

Sree Charani led the rout with flight, turn and relentless accuracy as Pakistan were bowled out for 55, their lowest total in women's T20s, in their Asia Cup clash in Dubai on Sunday.

Charani (3/7) and Prema Rawat (3/9) did most of the damage as India's spinners ran through Pakistan's batting order. Deepthi Sharma (2/5) and Shafali Verma (1/10) too joined the party, repeatedly drawing batters into shots away from their body and into the off-side, only for the ball to grip just enough to beat them. "Just need to bowl to our strength, give more revs on the ball. Just trying to bowl on the stumps," Charani said. "Trying to get more consistency on my arm ball, and more accuracy on the yorkers."

Electing to bat, Pakistan began cautiously to reach 27/0, although Muneeba Ali was fortunate to survive a couple of chances. Shafali eventually cleaned her act and the floodgates opened. Charani then struck twice in the final over of the Powerplay and Pakistan went from 27/0 to 35/6 in the blink of an eye as Rawat also ran through the middle order.

There was little respite after that. India's spinners kept tossing the ball up, inviting Pakistani batters to take the bait, while extracting enough turn to make stroke-making treacherous. Pakistan skipper Fatima Sana's dismissal only underlined the scale of their predicament, trapped leg before by a sharply turning Deepthi delivery. With the

lower order exposed, there was little resistance left as India wrapped up the innings in 18.1 overs.

For Charani, it was another statement performance in what has been a remarkable year. She has picked a whopping 32 wickets in 18 innings at an economy rate of 6.71 in 2026. The left-arm spinner has increasingly looked at home on the international stage, and against Pakistan she showed precisely why India have invested in her.

India's dominance came on a significant day for skipper Harmanpreet, who led the side in her 50th T20I — the first cricketer, male or female, to reach the landmark. India had already secured their place in the semi-finals before the game. Pakistan too are expected to progress despite the heavy defeat with Hong Kong their final group opponent.

It was India's spin quartet that dictated terms on a pitch where patience and deception were rewarded. Although India have a potent spin attack, Charani, Deepthi, Shafali and Rawat proved too good for the Pakistan batters. While chasing, Shafali hit a first-ball six, and it seemed India could even wrap it up within the Powerplay. However, Fatima Sana (3/17) rocked the top-order with three dismissals. She struck twice in the second over of the innings, sending back Shafali and Pratika Rawal, following it up by trapping Smriti Mandhana leg before in her second over. The rest of the chase, expectedly, proved a formality as India reached the target in 8.4 overs. Harmanpreet (18*) and Deepthi (12*) remained unbeaten as India eased to 57/3.

Brief scores: Pakistan 55 in 18.1 overs (S Charani 3/7, P Rawat 3/9) lost to India 57/3 in 8.4 overs (F Sana 3/17) by 7 wickets.

Away from her son, discus thrower Seema chases Asian Games dream

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NEW DELHI: The pause and lump in the throat is hard to miss as Seema Kaliramma talks about staying away from her four-year-old son, Rudra, while chasing her Asian Games dream.

The 27-year-old discus thrower returned with bronze from CWG in Glasgow, but there was little time to celebrate her first major medal with the Asian Games looming. She went home to Bhiwani for an overnight stay, attended a felicitation at her university and was back at the camp in Patiala the next day.

Seema is coached by her husband Ravinder Kaliramma, a former national-level thrower. That means the couple cannot spend much time with their son, who is looked after alternately by both sets of grandparents. Her happiest moments in Patiala came when she managed to spend a few days with Rudra. It is the kind of sacrifice she has made over the last four years to compete at the elite level. "It is very difficult for me because my son is not with me. I cannot bring him along because then I have to constantly watch over him and my training will suffer. He was here with me for 6-6 days and then I sent him home because I want to focus on Asian Games," Seema told HT during an interaction facilitated by SAL. "There are days when I have to tell myself, 'I want to be with you,' so that's the toughest part. It is quite emotional. It makes me think, 'Am I taking away part of his childhood from him?' Had he been with me, it would have been a different experience. Then I remind myself that whatever is happening right now, it'll be good for both of us in the future. My son comes for a day or two, but I

Seema Kaliramma

DISCUS THROWER

59.73m

Personal best

5TH

59.73m is 5th best throw in Asia in 2026

27-YR-OLD

Hails from Haryana's Bhiwani district

Achievements in 2026

Glasgow Commonwealth Games

World Athletics Continental Tour

National Championships

National Federation Cup

58.65m

BRONZE

COMMONWEALTH GAMES BRONZE MEDALLIST (2026)

3-TIME

NATIONAL CHAMPION

Seema overcame arthritis after giving birth to her son (Rudra)

INDIA

57.44m

4TH

59.73m

GOLD

57.29m

GOLD

don't remember the last time I went home and shared a meal with my family completely relaxed. It must have been 3-4 years. This time, after CWG, it was a quick visit, home, and I was back in Patiala."

Seema's career hasn't exactly run smooth. After her son was born, her comeback looked unlikely. She had been possible without and at one point, even walking a few steps was difficult. Her husband's constant encouragement helped spark her return to the field. After missing two seasons, she returned to the sport in 2024, gradually picking up from where she had left off in 2021. "As an athlete you have to make sacrifices. My journey is a little different because I am also a mother. But it

is inspiring when my son tells me 'You have to win a medal for the country.' Ek janoon le ke aata hai (It brings about that passion)."

Seema is also pursuing a PhD in physical education from Chaudhary Bansi Lal University. On rest days, she takes out time to focus on her course. "It could not have been possible without the support of my family. My husband is my coach. My son is with my parents, and then he will go to my husband's parents. For Seema, a prized possession from Glasgow was the memento Rudra had asked her to bring home. "When I came home, he knew that my mummy had won a big medal. He also came to Delhi for the reception.

The CWG medal has brought a lot of happiness to my family. The Glasgow medal has helped revive India's legacy in women's discus throw. At the 2010 Delhi Commonwealth Games, Krishna Poonia, Harvart Kaur and Seema Antil swept the podium. Seema Antil went on to win four CWG and three Asian medals. In 2022, however, India had no women's discus medal in CWG. "I don't know why we got a little behind. But now it has improved both in boys and girls. There are so many entries in national championships. Girls are throwing in the range of 55-60m. In the CWG, two of us (Nidhi Ranj) participated and at the Asian Games too, we will be there," says Seema.

A SPECIAL SHAMI CENTURY ADDS GLOW TO DULEEP TROPHY FINAL

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KOLKATA: There is something quietly defiant about Mohammed Shami still turning up. At 36, with 89 first-class games behind him and a 100th waiting in the Duleep Trophy final versus South Zone starting in Chennai on Sunday, Shami finds himself at an awkward intersection of achievement and uncertainty.

The milestone is significant. The circumstances are less so. India's selectors have, through their decisions, suggested that the fast bowler is no longer part of their immediate plans.

Shami, however, continues to behave as if the argument remains open. "He is just one of the best. He has been a legend of this game. He has been doing so well since he started playing for Bengal. He has been picking wickets, giving all his energy and he has done so well for the Indian cricket team also," his East Zone captain Ishan Kishan said on Saturday. "It's hard to say when it comes to age, I feel age is just a number. If he is working hard it doesn't matter. I see that hunger in Shami bhai because who better than me to judge about hunger right now."

The hunger Kishan suggests is not abstract. He has seen it at close quarters. "He has been doing so well, especially having him in our team it gives us a bit of more confidence."

There's a revealing detail in Kishan's description of Shami's contribution this season. The seasoned fast bowler has not been content to just fulfil his allocation of overs. "Looking at his efforts as a captain I felt very nice, because Shami bhai came in asking me for those extra overs to get the wickets. This is something which always gives confidence to skippers."

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